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PROJS WORTH RS 214 CR

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FORTY-SIX PEOPLE INJURED IN RAIN-RELATED INCIDENTS

56 killed as heavy rains trigger flood-like conditions across UP

BISWAJEET BANERJEE

Lucknow, September 27

Fifty-six people have died and 46 others were injured in rain- and storm-related incidents across Uttar Pradesh since September 25, with intense rainfall leaving several districts waterlogged, damaging 1,021 houses and killing 107 animals, officials said on Sunday. Rescue teams were deployed in inundated areas to evacuate stranded residents as rivers in parts of the state continued to rise, raising concerns over flooding in low-lying areas.

Relief Commissioner Dr Hrishikesh Bhaskar Yashod said the state received 66.5 mm of rain between September 25 and the morning of September 27, compared with the normal 7.6 mm for the period. This was 775



People carry their belongings to safer places in Prayagraj, on Sunday PTI

per cent above normal. Of Uttar Pradesh's 75 districts, 56 recorded excessive rainfall.

Sitapur reported the highest number of deaths at seven, followed by Lakh-

impur Kheri, Bahraich and Balrampur with five each. Ayodhya and Gorakhpur recorded four deaths each. Hardoi had the highest number of injured people at seven, while Mainpuri,

Shravasti and Barabanki reported five each.

The rainfall also caused extensive damage to livestock and homes. Hardoi recorded 28 animal deaths, followed by Sitapur with 16

and Kannauj with 14. Bahraich and Kanpur Dehat reported seven each, while Unnao recorded six. Hardoi had the largest number of damaged houses at 272, followed by

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HIGHLIGHTS

- » Heavy rains damage 1,021 houses across UP
- » Rainfall kills 107 animals across the state
- » Sitapur records highest deaths, with seven fatalities
- » Lakhimpur Kheri, Bahraich, Balrampur report five deaths each
- » Ayodhya, Gorakhpur report four deaths each
- » UP receives 775 per cent above-normal rainfall
- » Fifty-six of UP's 75 districts record excess rainfall
- » Farrukhabad rainfall exceeds normal by 7,385 per cent
- » Ghagra crosses danger level at Elginbridge

NEET PAPER LEAK IMPACT

CISF to guard NTA premises; stricter monitoring for 'confidential' areas

MPOST BUREAU

New Delhi, September 28

The National Testing Agency (NTA) has moved its confidential and sensitive operations to a new office in central Delhi, where 39 Central Industrial Security Force (CISF) personnel have been deployed to strengthen access control and security following controversies over examination paper leaks and administrative lapses.

The new facility, spread across more than 55,000 square feet in the Government of India Press Building on Minto Road, has been allotted space on the fifth floor and parts of the fourth and sixth floors. A senior official said the NTA shifted its confidential operations to the building over the past month.

The Home Ministry has approved CISF security for the premises, with personnel deployed at entry and exit points to regu-



FILE PHOTO/ANI

KEY POINTS

- » NTA's new Delhi office gets CISF security cover
- » 39 CISF personnel deployed at NTA premises
- » Security covers confidential examination operations
- » New office spans over 55,000 square feet
- » Facility is located on

Minto Road

- » NTA shifted sensitive operations there last month
- » CISF will regulate entry and exit points
- » Personnel will frisk entrants to confidential areas
- » X-ray baggage scanners will strengthen security checks
- » Door Frame Metal Detectors will screen entrants

late access to confidential areas. Security measures will include frisking, X-ray baggage screening machines and Door Frame Metal Detectors.

"The CISF is being deployed at suitable locations at all the entry and exit points for monitoring and regulation of access into the

CONTINUED ON P4

Briefs

SC to hear plea against UPI MDR today

NEW DELHI: The Supreme Court will on Monday hear a plea challenging the Centre's decision to impose a Merchant Discount Rate (MDR) on specified UPI person-to-merchant transactions above Rs 2,000. A bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant and Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana will hear the PIL filed by advocate Anjan Datta.

Under the framework announced on September 15, a 0.4 per cent MDR will apply from October 15, capped at Rs 300 for payments of Rs 75,000 and above. Essential sectors including railways, telecom, insurance, fuel and agricultural inputs will pay

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Russia backs India's bid for permanent seat at UNSC

UNITED NATIONS: Russia has backed India's bid for a permanent seat on the United Nations Security Council, while opposing any expansion that would add seats for Western countries, particularly Germany and Japan. Russian Foreign Minister Sergey Lavrov, addressing the UN General Assembly, said Moscow's position was that Security Council reform should broaden representation from Asia, Africa and Latin America rather than increase Western representation. "Our principled approach is the following: UN Security Council reform cannot involve

CONTINUED ON P4

Bank unions defer strike after IBA agrees to set up panel on five-day banking

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 27

Bank unions on Sunday deferred their three-day nationwide strike following assurance from the Indian Banks' Association (IBA) on their demands, including a five-day work week.

The strike call beginning Monday was given by the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU), which coincides with half-yearly closing.

With the postponement of the strike, banks would function on Monday.

"A high-level committee of the IBA and UFBU will be formed immediately to deliberate on the issue of declaring the remaining Saturdays as holidays. This committee will explore all possible alternatives, discuss with all the stakeholders, and work out a solution acceptable to all the stakeholders, more

WITH THE POSTPONEMENT OF THE STRIKE, BANKS WOULD FUNCTION ON MONDAY

importantly, the customers," the UFBU said in a statement.

As regards the PLI scheme for Scale IV and above officers, the discussions can start with the IBA to propose modifications in the scheme to the government to address the observations of the unions/associations, it said.

The residual issues as listed in the minutes dated March 8, 2024, will be discussed between the parties for expeditious resolution, it said.

In view of the above, it was agreed by the UFBU that the proposed agitation programmes and strike actions will be deferred, it added.

Surgical strikes showed India's new anti-terror resolve: PM Modi

OUR CORRESPONDENT

New Delhi, September 27

Prime Minister Narendra Modi on Sunday recalled the 2016 surgical strikes, saying the military operation marked a decisive response to terrorism and set a new example of India's counter-terrorism policy.

In his monthly radio programme Mann Ki Baat, Modi said India follows a



policy of zero tolerance towards terrorism and has

made clear that terrorist attacks would invite a strong response. He cited the Balakot air strike and Operation Sindoor as further instances of India's approach over the past decade.

Modi said the surgical strikes, carried out on September 28-29, 2016, would mark their 10th anniversary in a day. Indian Army personnel

CONTINUED ON P4

KOHLI JOINS 15,000 ODI-RUN CLUB



Virat Kohli became only second batter after Sachin Tendulkar to reach 15,000 ODI runs, achieving landmark during India's first ODI against West Indies on Sunday PTI

SQUASH STARS FALL SHORT OF OLYMPIC BERTHS

Six-medal Sunday, but gold slips away twice

MPOST BUREAU

Nagoya, September 27

India added six medals to its Asian Games tally on Sunday, with four coming from athletics and two from squash, as Ancy Sojan and Sarvesh Kushare won silver in their respective finals and Parul Chaudhary and Harita Bhadra claimed bronze. Anahat Singh and Abhay Singh also finished runners-up in squash, taking India's medal tally to 37 with four gold, 16 silver and 17 bronze at the Games.

Ancy came within two centimetres of gold in the women's long jump. Her fifth-attempt effort of 6.53m put her in the lead, but China's Huang Yingying produced 6.55m on her final attempt to snatch the gold.

India narrowly missed another medal in the event.



Ancy Sojan celebrates PTI

Shaili Singh's best jump of 6.42m had put her in

contention for bronze, but China's Mengyi Tan moved

ahead with 6.46m.

Sarvesh also had to set-

tle for silver after leading the men's high

CONTINUED ON P4

CLOSER LOOK

- » India won six medals across athletics and squash
- » Athletics contributed four medals to India's tally
- » Ancy Sojan won silver in women's long jump
- » Sarvesh Kushare won silver in men's high jump
- » Parul Chaudhary secured bronze in steeplechase
- » Harita Bhadra won bronze in women's 200m
- » Abhay Singh won squash singles silver
- » Anahat Singh also secured squash singles silver
- » Three Indian boxers assured additional medals

Punjab: LPU students go on rampage over alleged rape on campus

MPOST BUREAU

Phagwara, September 27

A protest by students at Lovely Professional University (LPU) in Punjab's Phagwara turned violent on Sunday, with agitators allegedly damaging campus property, attacking police vehicles and blocking NH-44 over claims that a female student was raped on the university premises.

The protest began around 1 am near Girls' Hostel-3 after students alleged that a female student staying there had been raped by a plumber three days earlier. They also claimed the hostel warden had been informed, but no action was taken.

The university denied that any rape had occurred and described the allegations as "rumours". LPU Registrar Monica Gulati said certain anti-social elements were spreading "false, baseless and fabricated" claims. The university also released a video in which three female students from Room No. 504 of Girls' Hostel-3 said no such incident had taken place.

Despite several rounds of talks, the protest continued. Students blocked the Delhi-Amritsar National

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GGM: Two children killed as cement water tank collapses

Accused contractor will be arrested soon: Police

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Gurugram, September 27

Two children, including a four-year-old girl, died after a cement water tank suddenly collapsed in shanties near the G-21 Society in Sector 83 of Gurugram, police said on Sunday.

The mothers of the two children were also injured as they were caught in the debris during the incident.

An FIR was registered against the contractor responsible for constructing the tank under Section 106 of the BNS at Kherki Daula police station, and police have launched an investigation.

According to the police, Sharif Ali, a resident of Malda in West Bengal, has been working as a mason while living in a rented shanty in Sector 83 for about a year. His wife, Rubina Bibi, is employed in housekeeping at a nearby housing society.



CLOSER LOOK

» According to the police, Sharif Ali, a resident of Malda in West Bengal, has been working as a mason while living in a rented shanty in Sector 83 for about a year. His wife, Rubina Bibi, is employed in housekeeping at a nearby society

» A cement tank measuring approximately 10 feet in length, 5 feet in width, and 5 feet in height was built in the shanty area just three or four days ago to store water: Complaint

» Rubina had gone to the tank to bathe her four-year-old daughter, Sumaiya. Another woman had also arrived to bathe her young son. Suddenly, the wall of the tank collapsed, falling onto both children and the women: Police

The complaint states that a cement tank mea-

suring approximately 10 feet in length, 5 feet in

width, and 5 feet in height was built in the shanty area just three or four days ago to store water. After the tank was completed on September 25, it was filled with water, and residents were advised to start using it. At that time, Rubina had gone to the tank to bathe her four-year-old daughter, Sumaiya. Another woman had also arrived to bathe her young son. Suddenly, the wall of the tank collapsed, falling onto both children and the women, according to police.

Locals worked to clear the debris and managed to pull the injured individuals out. Both children were rushed to the hospital, where doctors pronounced them dead.

“An FIR has been registered, and we handed over the bodies of the children to their kin after the postmortem. The accused contractor will be arrested soon”, said a senior police officer.

24 yrs after murder, cops apprehend accused working as tailor in Manesar

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

A 48-year-old man wanted for murdering a 35-year-old acquaintance by allegedly crushing his head with stones in a forested area of south Delhi in 2002 was arrested after evading the police for nearly 24 years, an officer said on Sunday.

The accused, identified as Firoj alias Khaja, was arrested by the Delhi Police Crime Branch from a readymade garment factory in IMT Manesar, Gurugram, where he had been working as a tailor for the last two years, he said.

The murder case was registered at Okhla Industrial Area police station in connection with the killing of Kalaam Ansari.

“On February 18, 2002, a highly decomposed body of an approximately 35-year-old man was recovered from the DDA forest near Tughlaqabad Fort. The body was covered with stones and the victim’s head had been brutally crushed,” the police officer said.

The deceased was later identified as Ansari, a resi-



dent of West Champaran in Bihar.

During the investigation, police found that Ansari had come to Delhi for employment in 2001 along with Firoj. The probe also revealed an old family dispute involving Firoj’s brother Saahbjaan, who was married to a woman from Ansari’s village.

According to police, Saahbjaan was involved in a dispute with his wife. He later died by suicide in front of Ansari’s house.

“Firoj suspected Ansari’s family of being responsible for the circumstances leading to his brother’s sui-

cide and had expressed his intention to take revenge,” he added.

On February 15, 2002, Firoj allegedly took Ansari to the forest near Tughlaqabad and killed him by crushing his head with stones. He subsequently returned to Bihar and gave misleading information about Ansari’s whereabouts before absconding, he said.

The Crime Branch launched a fresh effort to trace him and conducted around 30 raids over the last two months, including several visits to Bihar.

Teams developed infor-

mation about his movements by analysing old records and pursuing leads through sustained field work. The police eventually learnt that Firoj was working at a garment factory in IMT Manesar.

A team arrested him after keeping surveillance on the factory and confirming his identity.

Police said Firoj had severed contact with his native village after the murder and shifted to different places while concealing his identity and whereabouts. He is married and has four children. Further investigation is underway.

Briefs

Delhi Police resolves 2,809 complaints

NEW DELHI: The Delhi Police resolved 2,809 complaints during its ‘Jansunwai’ programme held across all 15 districts of the city, officials said on Sunday.

Senior officers, from the rank of Special Commissioner of Police to Assistant Commissioner of Police, attended the public hearing sessions held on Saturday and directly heard citizens’ grievances.

The initiative was launched in June following directions of Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu. Public hearings are held every Saturday from 10 am to 2 pm at police stations.

Man found dead inside barber shop

NEW DELHI: A 29-year-old man was found dead inside a barber shop in the Lawrence Road Industrial Area in northwest Delhi on Sunday, police said.

The deceased was identified as Zeeshan, was found unconscious inside he shop, they said. A PCR call regarding the incident was received at Keshav Puram police station, following which a police team rushed to the spot. “Zeeshan was taken to Deep Chand Bandhu Hospital, where doctors declared him brought dead. No visible injury marks were found on his body. The crime team inspected the spot and examined the circumstances surrounding the death,” a senior police officer said.

Prima facie, no foul play has come to light. Proceedings to ascertain the exact cause of death are underway, police said.

Over 14,000 challans issued in wk; wrong-side driving tops violations

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

The Delhi Traffic Police issued 14,160 challans and notices for various traffic violations during a week-long enforcement drive, with wrong-side driving accounting for the most violations, an officer said.

The drive was conducted from September 20 to 26 across the national capital, with 10,434 challans and notices issued against motorists driving on the wrong side of the road.

According to the traffic police, wrong-side driv-



ing poses a serious risk to motorists, pedestrians and other road users and was therefore a key focus of the drive. During the period, 917 challans were issued for use of tinted glass, while 1,311 prosecutions were made against private

buses, according to data shared by the traffic police.

“A total of 691 challans were issued for improper or obstructive parking and 438 for permit violations,” police said.

The enforcement drive also resulted in 76 prose-

‘A TOTAL OF 691 CHALLANS WERE ISSUED FOR IMPROPER OR OBSTRUCTIVE PARKING AND 438 FOR PERMIT VIOLATIONS’

cutions for SC violations, 63 for RC violations, 44 for disobeying lawful directions and 50 for not wearing seat belts.

Additionally, 136 challans were issued under other enforcement heads, the traffic police said.

Sisters arrested for robbing delivery executive

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

Two sisters were arrested for allegedly robbing a delivery executive of parcels by throwing chilli powder in his eyes in Rohini, police said on Sunday.

The accused, Nancy Singh, 26, and Gracy Singh, 20, both residents of Karol Bagh, were arrested on Saturday and three stolen par-

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

Three members of a family were rescued after a fire broke out at a godown used for storing cloth and foam in a two-storey building in northeast Delhi’s Mandoli area on Sunday, police said.

They said two fire incidents were reported from the godown located in D Block, Harsh Vihar, and police teams rushed to the spot.

Four fire tenders, two ambulances and four Delhi Disaster Management Authority person-



FOUR FIRE TENDERS, TWO AMBULANCES... REACHED THE SPOT

nel reached the spot. The fire was doused and a thorough search of the building was conducted, but no person was found injured or trapped inside, police said.

“At the time of the incident, the ground floor was locked. Three members of the building owner’s family were safely evacuated,” a senior police officer said.

The ground floor had been rented out by the building owner to Himanshu, a resident of Sunder Nagri, who was using it for storing cloth and foam used for manufacturing weightlifting belts, police said. During a preliminary inquiry, a fire brigade officer assessed that the probable cause of the fire was a short circuit.

Further inquiry into the incident is underway.

Two in cop net for demanding Rs 3 crore from businessman

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

Delhi Police have arrested two men for allegedly running an extortion racket in the name of gangster Kapil Sangwan alias Nandu and demanding Rs 3 crore from a businessman, officials said on Sunday.

The accused, Rohit Arora, 47, of Dwarka, and

Sudhir Gahlot alias Chota Nandu, 44, of Uttam Nagar, allegedly made threatening calls to several businessmen and threatened their families with serious consequences. Police said they were also planning firing incidents at targets’ homes and business premises to create fear.

The case was registered at Bindapur police station

on September 6 following the extortion demand. During investigation, police identified at least five targets in Dwarka.

Arora was arrested from Sector 11, Dwarka, on September 23, followed by Gahlot’s arrest on September 24. Six mobile phones were recovered. Further investigation is underway.

‘DDA PARK TIMINGS SHOULD BE CLEARLY DISPLAYED’

After Aastha Kunj gang-rape, residents seek safer DDA parks, proper lighting..

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

The gang rape of a 17-year-old girl at Aastha Kunj Park in southeast Delhi’s Kalkaji area has highlighted safety and maintenance issues concerning the sprawling 142-acre green space and other such DDA parks, with residents and local RWAs flagging poor lighting, broken sections of the boundary walls and inadequate security.

Residents said the Delhi Development Authority (DDA) parks remain poorly lit in the evening and portions of boundary



walls are damaged, making it difficult to monitor movement in and around the premises.

“One of the biggest issues is that these are huge parks, which are under DDA, but there is no proper ownership. The recent incident has highlighted the problem. If the

‘ONE OF THE BIGGEST ISSUES IS THAT THESE ARE HUGE PARKS, WHICH ARE UNDER DDA, BUT THERE IS NO PROPER OWNERSHIP’

DDA is unable to properly upkeep these parks, it should let locals come together and form neighbourhood park safety committees, with members from Residents’ Welfare Associations (RWAs), police officials and others,” Ruby Makhija, secretary of Navjiwan RWA.

The suggestion falls in line with the global trend of shifting management of public parks from a state-funded model to a collaborative public-private partnership.

Makhija also said that DDA park timings should be clearly displayed and authorities should ensure proper illumination throughout the parks.

In the recent incident, the survivor, a resident of Faridabad, was allegedly gang raped by three men posing as police personnel at the park on Monday. It has led to scrutiny of security arrangements at

the DDA-maintained park, particularly after dark, as well as the monitoring of its multiple entry and exit points.

Residents questioned the DDA’s security and maintenance of its 16,000-acre green assets following the Aastha Kunj incident. The DDA said additional night guards, regular and bike patrolling, and lighting at identified dark spots had been introduced to improve safety. L-G TS Sandhu has directed a safety audit of all DDA parks by next week, with further measures expected.

GREATER NOIDA

Retired Udyog Bandhu GM dies after hotel fall

DIPIKA KIROLA
Greater Noida, September 27

A retired general manager of Udyog Bandhu Kendra, Lucknow, died after allegedly falling from a hotel window in Knowledge Park, Greater Noida, on Sunday morning. Hargovind Singh was in the city for the ongoing UP International Trade Show and was staying at a hotel in the area.

Police said the incident came to light when a hotel employee went to Singh’s room to deliver tea. After receiving no response, the employee looked outside and found him lying on the ground. Police from Beta-2 station reached the spot, while forensic teams exam-

SINGH, A LUCKNOW RESIDENT, HAD RETIRED AS GM OF UDYOG BANDHU KENDRA AND WAS LATER GIVEN AN EXTENSION BY THE STATE GOVERNMENT

ined the scene.

Singh, a Lucknow resident, had retired as GM of Udyog Bandhu Kendra and was later given an extension by the state government. Police said he had dinner with friends on Saturday night and allegedly consumed alcohol.

The circumstances surrounding the fall are being investigated. His body was sent for postmortem.

CM lays foundation for 53 projs worth Rs 214 cr

Govt to develop 1,062 roads, lanes across 27 unauthorised colonies

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, September 27

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday laid the foundation stones for 53 development projects worth Rs.214.12 crore in unauthorised colonies across Kirari, Bawana, Mundka, Narela and Nangloi Jat Assembly constituencies. The projects are expected to benefit around 1.75 lakh residents and focus on roads, lanes and drainage infrastructure.

Under the projects, 1,062 roads and lanes across 27 unauthorised colonies will be developed. The works include around 89.82 km of road network and 147.69 km of drainage network, with the government stating that the infrastructure is aimed at improving local connectivity and addressing waterlogging.

Kirari will account for the largest share, with 27 works in 14 unauthorised colonies at a cost of Rs.105.51 crore. The projects cover 640 roads and lanes, 50.71 km of roads and 101.42 km of drainage network. Bawana will see nine works worth Rs.38.83



INFRA WORKS

- » Under the projects, 1,062 roads and lanes across 27 unauthorised colonies will be developed. The works include around 89.82 km of road network and 147.69 km of drainage network, with the government stating that infra is aimed at improving local connectivity and addressing waterlogging.
- » Kirari will account for largest share, with 27 works in 14 unauthorised colonies at a cost of Rs.105.51 cr. Projects cover 640 roads & lanes, 50.71 km of roads and 101.42 km of drainage network. Bawana will see 9 works worth Rs.38.83 cr, while 5 works worth Rs.22.05 cr earmarked for Mundka

crore, while five works worth Rs.22.05 crore have been earmarked for Mundka. Narela will get four projects worth Rs.14.48 crore and Nangloi Jat eight works worth Rs.33.25 crore.

Speaking at the event,

Gupta said the government was focusing on areas that had faced infrastructure-related problems for a long time.

“The Delhi Government’s objective is to strengthen basic civic amenities in every part

of the city,” she said.

She added that roads, drains, sewerage and drainage were “basic rights of every citizen” and said development would be taken to “every lane and every area of Delhi”.

PWD and Water Minister Parvesh Sahib Singh said the government’s development drive would extend beyond major roads. “The pace of development will not remain confined to the main roads, but will reach every lane and every household in unauthorised colonies,” he said.

Social Welfare Minister Ravindra Indraj Singh said there would be no discrimination in development works or budget allocation among Assembly constituencies. He said Rs.105 crore had been made available for development works in Kirari.

The foundation-laying programme was held as part of the Delhi government’s Seva Sankalp campaign. The Chief Minister also listened to the 138th episode of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s Mann Ki Baat with citizens and public representatives

Gupta backs ECI’s SIR exercise & urges Opp’n to use legal channels

AIMAN FATIMA
New Delhi, September 27

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Sunday hit out at the Opposition over its allegations against the Election Commission and the electoral process, accusing it of creating “baseless” controversy and attempting to divert public attention from development issues.

Addressing reporters at Janseva Sadan, Gupta questioned the Opposition’s criticism of the poll panel’s functioning and said political parties should raise concerns through constitutional and legal channels. “Everyone has the right to ask questions in a democracy, but such questions should be based on facts,” she said.

Her remarks came amid the ongoing political row over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls. The Election Commission’s voter services portal currently provides facilities for SIR-related submissions, including Form 6 for new voter registration and a separate declaration form.

On questions surrounding Form 6, Gupta said the original form had not been changed and that a separate declaration had been added for the SIR process. She said the exercise was

‘VOTE CHORI’

» For Delhi, the ECI schedule lists Sept 20 to Oct 20 as claims and objections period and Oct 7 as the publication date for the final electoral roll

» Gupta alleged that the Opposition began questioning the electoral process when election results did not go its way

» Referring to the BJP’s 2014 LS victory, she asked whether similar questions had been raised about Election Commission

» ‘You may spread as much false propaganda as you want to mislead the people, but the people are watching everything’

aimed at verifying electoral roll entries and retaining eligible voters while identifying entries that may have become invalid because of death, shifting or duplication.

The CM also questioned the Opposition’s allegations of “vote chori” and said electoral rolls needed to be updated through verification and claims and objections.

For Delhi, the ECI schedule lists September 20 to October 20 as the claims and objections period and October 7 as the publication date for the final electoral roll.

Gupta alleged that the Opposition began questioning the electoral process when election results did not go its way. Referring to the BJP’s 2014 Lok Sabha victory, she asked whether similar questions had been raised about the

Election Commission at that time.

“You may spread as much false propaganda as you want to mislead the people, but the people are watching everything. The people will answer each and every point. Lies have no legs,” she said.

Gupta also criticised Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and other Opposition leaders over their statements on the issue. She said their activities were, in her view, “no less than treason” and said cases of treason should be registered against them.

The Chief Minister maintained that political parties had a responsibility to preserve public trust in constitutional institutions and said concerns over the electoral process should be backed by evidence and raised through prescribed mechanisms.

SUV hits bike, two injured on Dwarka Expressway

PRAJYOT DEOGHARE
New Delhi, September 27

A motorcyclist and his pillion rider were injured after a Mahindra Thar Roxx allegedly rammed into their vehicle on the Dwarka Expressway on Saturday night and fled the spot.

The incident was captured on the dashboard camera of a car travelling behind the SUV, according to police. The footage purportedly shows the Thar Roxx changing lanes from the left-side service lane and attempting to overtake the car and motorcycle.

The SUV allegedly accelerated through a gap between the two vehicles and struck the motorcycle, throwing both riders off the road. Both were wearing helmets and sustained minor injuries, according to an NDTV report. The SUV driver allegedly fled without stopping.

Police later traced the vehicle’s registration number. Details on the eChallan Parivahan portal showed a pending Rs 5,000 fine for rash driving and jumping a red light, issued on August 3.

The incident comes amid other reported Thar-related crashes in the NCR.

Briefs

Student dies after balcony fall in Gzb

GHAZIABAD: A13-year-old Class 7 student died after allegedly falling from the balcony of her 10th-floor apartment at Gulmohar Greens Society in Sahibabad on Saturday night. Her family alleged that repeated harassment by a teacher over her performance in mathematics had caused her severe mental distress.

Police said the girl suddenly fell from the balcony and was taken to Narendra Mohan Hospital, where doctors declared her dead. The family told police she had been reprimanded and humiliated in front of classmates and had written about the incidents in her school diary. They also claimed she had spoken to friends about suicide.

Boy missing 21 months traced in Gzb

NEWDELHI: A15-year-old boy who left his Todapur home following a dispute with his parents over studies was traced in Ghaziabad after nearly 21 months, police said on Sunday.

The boy went missing on December 25, 2024, after his parents insisted he attend school regularly and focus on studies.

He allegedly stayed away from his family and worked at hotels and shops.

Police searched 153 CCTV cameras, 24 shelter homes and 27 orphanages across Delhi-NCR.

Acting on local information, a police team traced him in Ghaziabad on September 25. His mother later identified him.

MCD regularises services of 501 sanitation workers

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, September 27

The Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) has regularised the services of 501 sanitation workers who had been serving the civic body for several years, the Mayor’s office said on Sunday.

Mayor Pravesh Wahi congratulated the workers and said the decision would provide them and their families with greater employment stability and social security.

He said the move recognised the contribution of sanitation workers to maintaining cleanliness across the national capital.

“Sanitation workers are the backbone of Delhi’s cleanliness system,” Wahi said, adding that the civic body had a responsibility to honour their contribution and safeguard their interests.

The Mayor said the MCD had recently regularised the services of 296 sanitation workers and

described the latest decision as part of the Corporation’s continued efforts towards the welfare of its sanitation workforce.

He said sanitation workers worked daily under challenging conditions and played a vital role in keeping Delhi clean.

Ensuring that they received their rightful entitlements and benefits was among the Corporation’s priorities, he added.

The Mayor’s office said the regularisation was not merely an administrative decision but also a recognition of the workers’ years of service and dedication.

The move is expected to provide the employees and their families with a more stable employment framework and a stronger social security base.

Wahi said the Corporation would continue to pursue measures concerning the welfare and interests of its employees with priority and sensitivity.

DDA seeks developers’ views on in-situ slum rehabilitation

SHIVANGI SHUKLA
New Delhi, September 27

The Delhi Development Authority (DDA) on September 25 held an Investors Meet with developers to discuss its In-Situ Slum Rehabilitation Programme and seek their views on a practical framework for implementing rehabilitation projects across Delhi.

The meeting provided a platform for developers and other stakeholders to discuss project structures, implementation mechanisms, risk allocation, financing and approval processes. The feedback will help the DDA refine the proposed framework as the programme moves towards procurement and implementation.

The Master Plan for Delhi 2047 (MPD-2047) envisages the in-situ rehabilitation of around 17 lakh residents of JJ clusters. The programme aims to improve housing and living conditions for eligible residents at their existing locations, while promoting integrated neighbourhood

CLOSER LOOK

» Meet provided a platform for developers and other stakeholders to discuss project structures, implementation mechanisms, risk allocation, financing and approval processes

» Feedback will help DDA refine proposed framework as the programme moves towards procurement & implementation

» DDA said successful implementation would require close coordination among public institutions, private developers and communities, with residents’ needs remaining central

development, better urban infrastructure and more efficient land use.

The DDA said in-situ rehabilitation was an important component of the vision of Viksit Bharat 2047, which seeks to create opportunities for all. The proposed framework aims to unlock redevelopment potential while promoting inclusive and sustainable urban growth.

Addressing the gathering, the DDA Vice-Chairman stressed the role of the private sector in meeting the scale of rehabilitation and redevelopment required in Delhi. The initiative seeks to create sustainable neighbour-

hoods while providing safe and dignified housing, improved infrastructure and more efficient land utilisation. The DDA said successful implementation would require close coordination among public institutions, private developers and communities, with residents’ needs remaining central to the planning and execution of projects. The meeting was organised in line with the directions of Delhi Lieutenant Governor Sardar Taranjit Singh Sandhu.

The authority will continue engaging with the development community as the project framework evolves.

REIMAGINING THE COSMOS

Nehru Planetarium gets high-tech makeover

ANAMTA FATIMA
New Delhi, September 27

Stepping inside the iconic dome at Teen Murti Bhawan feels remarkably different these days. For decades, visitors walked into the Nehru Planetarium greeted by the steady hum of a classic Carl Zeiss optical projector, tracking stars across the night sky with old-school precision.

Today, that nostalgic charm meets cutting-edge innovation. Following a comprehensive facelift, the capital’s premier astronomy hub has flung open its doors with a suite of upgraded facilities designed to ignite curiosity in a new generation of stargazers.

Dr. Y. Ravi Kiron, Director of the Nehru Plane-



tarium, emphasises that the overhaul is about much more than just aesthetics. “These kinds of experiments are done for 9th class to 12th class, even degree graduates,” Dr. Kiron notes, pointing to hands-on educational activities like shadow-tracking and equinox experiments that bring ancient astronomical calculations to life for stu-



dents visiting from across the country. The modernisation touches nearly every corner of the 1984-built institution. Gone are the days when eager young minds had to wait idly outside; visitors can now retreat to a newly minted reading room-cum-library or unwind in a newly designed lounge.

Furthermore, the planetarium has shifted

away from passive viewing toward immersive engagement, introducing cutting-edge 8K projection capabilities alongside interactive workshops tailored for younger demographics, including Generation Z and Generation Alpha.

From exploring the mechanics of Earth’s rotation through elementary trigonometry to schedul-

FOLLOWING A COMPREHENSIVE FACELIFT, CAPITAL’S PREMIER ASTRONOMY HUB HAS FLUNG OPEN ITS DOORS WITH A SUITE OF UP-GRADED FACILITIES...

ing upcoming shows on Chandrayaan alongside international space agency features, the refurbished planetarium bridges historical legacy with futuristic tech.

As it continues to foster a scientific temper among visitors of all ages, Teen Murti Bhawan proves that looking up at the stars is an endless, ever-evolving adventure.

43 Sundays of NDMC plantation campaign

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

The New Delhi Municipal Council (NDMC) organised a plantation drive at Central Government Employees’ F Block RWA in Moti Bagh on Sunday as part of its ‘Ek Ped Maa Ke Naam’ campaign, marking the 43rd consecutive Sunday of the initiative.

NDMC Vice-Chairperson Kuljeet Singh Chahal, along with residents, RWA representatives and civic officials, participated in the drive. Residents planted saplings in honour of their mothers and pledged to protect and nurture them.

Before the plantation activity, Chahal and residents listened to the 138th episode of Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s ‘Mann Ki Baat’.

Chahal said plantation

should not end with planting a sapling, stressing the need for regular watering, nourishment and protection to ensure its growth into a healthy tree. He also said sustained public participation was essential for creating greener neighbourhoods and protecting the environment.

A separate plantation programme was held at Atal Adarsh School Primary, Moti Bagh. During the visit, the school principal raised issues related to building repairs, white-washing, monkey menace and sewerage.

Chahal directed officials to inspect the issues and take necessary action within the stipulated timeframe, stressing direct engagement with residents and addressing grassroots concerns for responsive civic governance.

POLITICAL BATTLE INTENSIFIES OVER SIR

Cong slams ECI's 'piecemeal steps'; BJP says those benefiting from 'dirty rolls' crying foul

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, September 27

Political tensions over the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls intensified on Sunday, with the Congress and CPI(M) questioning the Election Commission's latest measures for voters whose names have been deleted or are at risk of deletion, while the BJP defended the exercise as a necessary clean-up of electoral rolls.

The BJP said more than one crore duplicate entries and 2.8 crore names of deceased voters had been removed from electoral rolls across 31 states and Union territories under the SIR exercise. It accused those who had benefited from what it called "dirty rolls" of now objecting to efforts to clean them up.

The party also said 9.43 crore absent and shifted names had been identified and removed from elec-

toral rolls, describing this as 9.92 per cent of the total electorate on the rolls. In a post on X, the BJP asked who had benefited from keeping duplicate names on the rolls and why the opposition was objecting to the exercise.

BJP spokesperson Sudhanshu Trivedi said the Election Commission's statement on Saturday made clear that all major decisions, including the SIR, had been taken unanimously by Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi. He accused the Congress of misleading people and questioning the credibility of constitutional institutions.

The BJP's response came a day after the Election Commission announced a series of decisions covering issues that Sandhu and Joshi had



raised in internal communications over the previous 10 months. These included changes to voter registration forms, access to electoral-roll databases and the functioning of its IT systems.

The developments followed a report by The Indian Express that Sandhu and Joshi had recorded objections on at least 14 occasions over the 10-month period to deci-

sions and orders, some of which they said had been issued without their knowledge.

The Congress challenged the BJP's figures on deleted voters. Its media and publicity department head Pawan Kherra questioned the claim that 2.8 crore of the deleted names belonged to deceased voters. Kherra said 13 crore voters had been removed under the SIR and asked

what had happened to the remaining 10.2 crore names.

He also questioned whether the BJP's claim indicated that electoral rolls had not been properly maintained for years, asking where the remaining names had gone if they were not deceased voters.

Congress general secretary in-charge communications Jairam Ramesh separately attacked the Election Commission's latest measures, calling them "piecemeal" steps that, in the Congress's view, would do little to address what it described as "mass disenfranchisement".

Ramesh said 5.43 crore voters were at risk of deletion and questioned the Commission's proposal for Booth Level Officers (BLOs) to visit their homes again. He argued that such visits were already supposed to have taken place during the house-to-house

enumeration phase and alleged that they had been "sparse and sporadic".

For voters already deleted, Ramesh said the Commission's response was to require them to apply afresh to Electoral Registration Officers for inclusion. He questioned the logic of deleting voters and then requiring them to seek re-entry into the rolls.

Ramesh also raised questions about ECINet software, alleging that it had been involved in the deletion of eligible voters and could override Electoral Registration Officers. He said the Commission's proposal to create a committee to certify that the software complies with the relevant Acts and Rules indicated that questions remained over its legality. He also raised concerns about the lack of transparency over the use of artificial intelligence in electoral-roll preparation.

ECI dubs CEC Kumar's purported resignation letter as 'fake'

MPOST BUREAU
New Delhi, September 27

The Election Commission on Sunday termed a purported resignation letter of Chief Election Commissioner (CEC) Gyanesh Kumar as "fake".

A letter addressed to President Droupadi Murmu and purportedly signed by Kumar, announcing his resignation as the CEC, was widely shared on social media. Responding to the so-called "resignation letter", an EC spokesperson described it as "fake".

The opposition has been demanding the CEC's resignation after a news report claimed differences between Election Commissioners S S Sandhu and Vivek Joshi and Kumar over decisions and orders related to the Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of electoral rolls.

The EC on Saturday asserted that all

A LETTER ADDRESSED TO PRESIDENT DROUPADI MURMU AND PURPORTEDLY SIGNED BY KUMAR, ANNOUNCING HIS RESIGNATION AS THE CEC, WAS WIDELY SHARED ON SOCIAL MEDIA

orders related to the SIR exercise were issued after approval from all three election commissioners, and the changes in Form 6, through which names are included in the voters' list, have been upheld by the Supreme Court. The EC, in a statement, said that letters sent by the two commissioners to the Cabinet secretary were not related to any policy matter of the commission or its IT division, but to the working of an officer on deputation to the poll panel.

From page 1

56 killed as heavy rains

Sitapur with 108, Chandauli with 75 and Auraiya with 60.

Rainfall totals were far above normal in several districts. Farukhabad recorded 7,385 per cent more rain than normal, followed by Kannauj at 5,664 per cent, Shahjahanpur at 4,408 per cent, Hamirpur at 4,240 per cent and Mahoba at 4,100 per cent.

The Central Water Commission said the Ghagra and Rapti rivers were rising at several monitoring stations. At Elginbridge in Barabanki, the Ghagra stood at 106.14 metres at 8 am, above its danger mark of 106.07 metres, and was expected to rise further to 106.55 metres by Sunday night. In Ayodhya, the river was at 92.39 metres against a warning level of 91.73 metres, with a projected rise to 92.85 metres.

The Rapti was also above its warning level at Balrampur, where the water stood at 104 metres against 103.62 metres and was expected to rise further.

The weather system responsible for the prolonged spell weakened from a depression into a well-marked low-pressure area early Sunday, according to the India Meteorological Department. The system was moving north-northwestwards across Uttar Pradesh and was expected to weaken further. The state received 45.1 mm of rain in the 24 hours ending Sunday, against a normal 1.8 mm.

Heavy rain and winds of 30-40 kmph affected Kanpur, Varanasi, Prayagraj, Gorakhpur, Bareilly and other areas. Roads and villages were inundated, while trees and electric poles were uprooted. A roughly 200-metre stretch of the Kanpur-Etawah highway was also reported damaged.

In Lucknow, a portion of the road near Ekana Stadium reportedly caved in, while several intersections were waterlogged. Agricultural fields in Bakshi Ka Talab were submerged and crops were flattened.

The Ganga Expressway remained operational despite water accumulation at the Sonik toll plaza in Unnao. Project manager R S Mishra said traffic movement was normal, with waterlogging reported only at one ramp where drainage was partly affected by the relatively low height of a nearby high-tension power line.

Yashod reviewed rescue and relief operations with district officials and directed them to remain in the field, maintain contact with affected residents and provide immediate assis-

stance. Officials were also asked to assess crop losses, provide compensation under government rules and arrange alternative accommodation and housing benefits for eligible families whose homes were damaged.

Authorities urged residents to avoid unnecessary travel through waterlogged or flood-affected areas and keep away from fast-flowing rivers, streams and drains. The relief department's emergency helpline is 1070.

CISF to guard NTA

confidential area," the official said.

The move follows serious concerns over security arrangements at the NTA's previous office in Okhla. According to a CBI chargesheet in the NEET-UG paper leak case, three subject experts allegedly acted as primary sources of the leaked paper. The chargesheet said there was no checking or frisking of experts entering or leaving the confidential section, allowing them to carry portions of the question paper written on small chits made from plain sheets supplied for rough work and translation.

The CBI also found that the NTA office did not have a dedicated control room for live monitoring of CCTV footage, allowing the activities of the accused experts to go unnoticed.

The NEET-UG paper leak triggered nationwide protests and led to the resignation of then Union Education Minister Dharmendra Pradhan. A day later, Prime Minister Narendra Modi announced a high-powered task force headed by Infosys co-founder Nandan Nilekani to recommend reforms to make examination systems more secure. The panel has not yet submitted its report.

The latest security measures also came after the Supreme Court criticised the NTA following the 2026 paper leak, observing that the agency "has not learnt its lessons".

The NTA, established in 2017 under the Ministry of Education to conduct fair, transparent and standardised examinations, is also working on technical safeguards. These include stricter access controls, encryption standards, immutable logging and tamper-evident storage for examination-critical systems.

The agency plans security readiness reviews of systems before every examination cycle, covering areas such as candidate registration, admit cards, computer-based testing, OMR processing, result systems and examination-day workflows. The measures will also include biometric authentication, face matching, CCTV and live mon-

itoring. The NTA is preparing examination-specific cyber-incidents response arrangements, including enhanced Security Operations Centre monitoring and rapid-response capabilities on examination days.

A dedicated chief information security officer has also been planned. The post of general manager and CISO has been advertised, and the selection process is at an advanced stage, the official said. Independent cyber-security audits by CERT-In and C-DAC-empanelled agencies are also continuing.

The NTA had previously been the subject of a high-level review after the 2024 NEET paper leak. A committee headed by former ISRO chairman K Radhakrishnan had recommended stronger security controls covering question paper systems, registration, payment, admit cards, testing platforms, OMR processing, normalisation and results.

The Government of India Press Building already has CISF security in other areas. The NTA's new arrangement makes it one of the examination-related establishments receiving such protection, alongside the Union Public Service Commission, which conducts recruitment examinations.

PM Modi

crossed the Line of Control (LoC) and targeted terrorist hideouts in Pakistan following the attack on an Army camp in Uri, Jammu and Kashmir, in which 18 soldiers were killed.

"The surgical strike boldly demonstrated to the entire world a new example of India's counter-terrorism policy," Modi said, describing the operation as a response to the pain caused by years of terrorist attacks.

He also recalled the September 13, 2008 serial blasts in Delhi and the subsequent 26/11 attacks in Mumbai. Modi said that in the past, calls for action against Pakistan after terror attacks were often followed by a wait for a response. His remarks came two days after Pakistan Prime Minister Shehbaz Sharif raised the Kashmir issue during his address to the UN General Assembly. Sharif called for a "just and fair solution" to prevent another major conflict in South Asia. India has consistently rejected Pakistan's claims on Kashmir and maintained that Jammu and Kashmir is an integral part of the country.

Modi also referred to Operation Sindoor, launched on May 7, 2025, against terror infrastructure in Pakistan and Pakistan-occupied Kashmir following the April 22 Pahalgam attack, in which 26 civilians were killed.

The prime minister also recalled the September 11, 2001 attacks in the United States, not-

ing that Indians were among the largest groups of foreign victims of the World Trade Centre attacks. He offered condolences to the families of those killed.

In the broadcast, Modi spoke about efforts against drug abuse under the Nasha Mukti Yuva Abhiyan, saying young people were pledging to stay away from drugs and encourage others to do the same.

He also paid tribute to Vishwa Hindu Parishad leader Ashok Singhal on his birth centenary, saying Singhal had also worked against social discrimination and inequality.

Modi spoke about the Somnath Swabhiman Parv and said the Somnath temple represented the continuity of India's heritage. He also highlighted cleanliness initiatives by young people in Madhya Pradesh, Andhra Pradesh, Mumbai, Delhi and West Bengal, including river and beach clean-ups, restoration of wells and stepwells, waste segregation and cleaning of public spaces.

Delhi minister Verma

condition of the road during the inspection. He claimed portions of the newly laid surface were coming off and alleged that the police helped the minister leave the spot. Singh said he had contacted the emergency response number 112 and demanded action against Verma. Former Delhi chief minister Arvind Kejriwal also shared the video and called for the minister's arrest.

Verma, responding to the allegations, said the video being circulated did not show the full context of the incident. He alleged that Singh and his supporters had been interfering with the road work and made allegations regarding pressure on PWD officials and contractors. These allegations could not be independently verified.

Explaining his reaction, Verma said one of the people accompanying Singh had allegedly abused his family. "When one of his workers started hurling abuses at my family, I reacted just as anyone would in the heat of the moment," he said.

The incident has brought the quality of the road work as well as the alleged physical altercation into focus, with the AAP demanding action against Verma and the minister disputing the Opposition's account of the events.

Punjab: LPU students

Highway-44 outside the campus from around 8 am, causing long traffic queues. Traffic was

diverted towards Phagwara-Jandiala Road for vehicles heading towards Jalandhar and through arterial roads.

Students demanded that LPU Founder-Chancellor Ashok Mittal, a BJP Rajya Sabha MP, visit the protest site. They also sought assurance that their University Management System access would not be blocked and that they would not face action for participating in the protest.

The situation deteriorated around 7.30 pm when police attempted to clear the highway blockade. Officials said protesters hurled bottles and later pelted stones at police, prompting a mild lathi charge. Several police personnel were injured, while four to five police vehicles were damaged, according to Jalandhar Rural SSP Harvinder Singh Virk. Two vehicles were also allegedly set on fire.

Videos circulating on social media showed damaged window panes, flower pots, vehicles and an ATM kiosk. Some protesters were also seen vandalising shops at the university mall, while others climbed onto a decommissioned MiG-23UM aircraft and a military tank installed on campus. A heavy police force was subsequently deployed from Kapurthala, Jalandhar Rural and Hoshiarpur.

Police registered a rape case against an unknown person based on the students' complaint and formed a special investigation team. DIG Jalandhar Range Naveen Singla said investigators would examine forensic samples, CCTV footage and call records before reaching a conclusion. Students have also demanded that hostel staff comprise only women.

Singla said the protesting students claimed the girl had returned home after no action was taken. He said the probe would involve student representatives.

The DIG also said a Telangana student at LPU had died by suicide 15 days earlier. If students raise concerns about foul play, he said, appropriate action would be taken.

The episode came a day after protests at Chitkara University in Patiala following unverified claims concerning the deaths of two female students.

SC to hear plea

Rs 5 per transaction above Rs 2,000. Mutual funds, securities and stockbroker payments will attract a 0.02 per cent MDR, also capped at Rs 300.

P2P UPI transfers, which account for 37 per cent of transaction volume and 70 per cent of value, will remain free.

The plea challenges the framework's statutory basis, transparency and impact on small merchants.

UNSC

any additional seats being allocated to Western countries, especially to Germany and Japan, who are now on the path to militarism and revanchism," Lavrov said.

He said Russia supported the candidatures of India and Brazil for permanent membership, while also calling for the interests of the African continent to be addressed.

Lavrov said Russia was working with its allies and strategic partners through groups including BRICS, the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation and the Eurasian Economic Union to address global issues.

He also said international information security was emerging as an important area of discussion and that the UN should have a central role in such deliberations rather than narrower international forums.

Six-medal Sunday

jump for much of the competition. He and Chinese Taipei's Chao Hsuan-Fu both cleared 2.25m, but Chao managed it on his first attempt while Sarvesh needed two. That difference placed the Indian second despite both athletes clearing the same height.

Parul secured her second consecutive Asian Games bronze in the women's 3000m steeplechase, improving on her previous performance with a personal best of 9:08.67. Bahrain's Winfred Yavi won gold, while Kazakhstan's Norah Jeruto Tanui took silver in 9:06.82. Harita completed India's athletics medal haul with bronze in the women's 200m. She clocked 23.20 seconds to finish third, behind Singapore's Shanti Pereira, who won gold in a season-best 22.78, and China's Chen Yujie, who took silver in 22.93.

Harita edged Japan's Ido Abigeirufuka, who finished fourth in 23.21, while India's Unnathi Aiyappa Bolland was sixth in 23.48.

Squash contributed two more silver medals, although India continued to wait for its first individual Asian Games gold in the sport.

Abhay Singh lost 11-9, 11-5, 11-5 to defending champion Ng Eain Yow in the men's singles final. The 24th-ranked Indian stayed close in the opening game, but the Malaysian controlled the pace and length of rallies thereafter, repeatedly forcing Abhay into difficult retrievals. The match lasted 44 minutes.

Abhay acknowledged the Malaysian's experience in major matches and said he would

return to the drawing board. He also pointed out that another route to Olympic qualification remains available.

Anahat Singh, 18, was beaten 4-11, 4-11, 7-11 by Malaysia's world No. 5 and defending champion Sivasangari Subramaniam in the women's singles final. The match lasted 27 minutes.

The two squash silvers continued India's wait for an individual Asian Games gold. Saurav Ghosal had also finished with silver at the 2014 and 2023 editions.

India's boxing campaign also produced important developments, with Parveen Hooda, Ankush Panghal and Narender Berwal advancing to the semifinals and assuring the country of three more medals.

Parveen defeated Uzbekistan's world championships silver medallist Navbakhor Khamidova 5-0 in the women's 65kg quarterfinal. It was her first bout of the Games after receiving a walkover in the previous round. She moved up from 57kg to 65kg following a 22-month suspension imposed by the International Testing Agency for a whereabouts failure and said she was gradually rebuilding her confidence.

Ankush, making his Asian Games debut after winning Commonwealth Games gold in Glasgow last month, beat Tajikistan's Nekruz Salimov 5-0 in the men's 80kg quarterfinal.

Narender, a bronze medallist at the previous Asian Games, needed less than two minutes to advance in the +90kg category. He forced referee stoppage against Thailand's Adthapong Saengteap after three standing counts. Sachin Siwach, however, lost 0-5 to Japan's Shunsuke Kitamoto in the men's 60kg quarterfinal.

India's individual badminton campaign ended without a medal. PV Sindhu, playing her third match in less than 24 hours, lost 21-11, 18-21, 10-21 to Olympic champion Chen Yu Fei. Nineteen-year-old Unnati Hooda also bowed out in the quarterfinals, losing 16-21, 21-14, 17-21 to three-time world champion Akane Yamaguchi.

Treesa Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand and the mixed doubles pair of Dhruv Kapila and Tanisha Crasto also lost their quarterfinals. India had won three badminton medals at Hangzhou, but this time the men's team bronze was the country's only medal from the competition.

The women's hockey team, meanwhile, maintained its unbeaten run with a 7-0 win over Singapore. The victory gave India five wins from five matches and top spot in Pool B, setting up a semifinal against Korea.

Briefs

Assam: CJP leader Ranka released

GUWAHATI: Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) leader Ashutosh Ranka on Sunday evening said the “illegal detention” of him and other volunteers by the Assam Police has “finally ended”.

He made the remarks in a post on X after being released along with the other detainees.

“The illegal detention by Assam Police has finally ended. We have asked Police to go and drop us from where we were picked up illegally in the first place,” Ranka said.

‘INLD to oust BJP’

NUH: INLD chief Abhay Chautala on Sunday expressed confidence that his party will form the next govt in Haryana by ousting the BJP, while the Congress, which he described as the BJP’s “B team”, will also be kept away from power.

He was addressing the ‘Samman Diwas’ rally organised to mark the 113th birth anniversary of former deputy PM and former Haryana CM Devi Lal.

Raj: Cong MLA Nayak detained

JAIPUR: Congress MLA Shimla Nayak, along with several farmers and party workers, was detained in Rajasthan’s Anupgarh on Sunday while they were on their way to protest during CM’s visit to Suratgarh, officials said.

The protesters were stopped by police at the Ghaggar river bridge, where barricades had been put up, the officials said.

Cong targets BJP over tribal rights

RAIPUR: The Congress on Sunday accused the BJP govt in Chhattisgarh of failing to protect tribal rights, create employment, ensure development in mining-affected areas and maintain law and order.

Addressing the media, newly appointed All India Congress Committee in-charge of Chhattisgarh Sukhdeo Bhatnagar alleged that forests were being cleared for mining projects in several areas, including Hasdeo Aranya.

Mehbooba Mufti meets Mirwaiz

SRINAGAR: PDP president Mehbooba Mufti on Sunday called on Kashmir’s chief cleric Mirwaiz Umar Farooq at his residence here, in a meeting that assumes significance amid growing concern over social issues affecting the valley’s youth.

The meeting comes days after the two publicly found common ground over the proposed “Tantra in Silence” retreat in north Kashmir’s Gurez valley over a week ago.

MONTHLY RADIO ADDRESS ‘MANN KI BAAT’

Census vital national duty: PM

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

Prime Minister Narendra Modi said on Sunday that Census is a national responsibility, urging citizens to self-enumerate online to ensure accurate data for planning the nation’s future.

In his monthly radio address Mann Ki Baat, he noted that so far more than 2.6 crore people have entered their details on the Census portal via mobile phones, completing the self-enumeration.

“Census is a national responsibility for all of us. It is important for the nation as accurate information about you and your family helps create a precise picture of the country’s future,” he said.

The Prime Minister said the online self-registration facility is highly convenient, allowing citizens to easily enter information for themselves and their families directly from their mobile phones.

Along with Hindi, this facility is available in 16 regional languages, he said.

“A grand picture of the nation is currently emerging. This picture includes you, your family and even your neighbours. I am referring to India’s Census. The first phase of this exercise is nearly complete across all states and union territories,” he said.

Modi said data of over 32 crore families has already been recorded and work is currently underway also in the remote, snow-clad



Prime Minister Narendra Modi PTI

KEY POINTS

- » Modi noted that so far more than 2.6 crore people have entered their details on the Census portal via mobile phones
- » The Prime Minister said the entire process takes about 15 to 20 minutes and for that no document is required to upload

regions of Ladakh, Himachal Pradesh, Jammu and Kashmir, and Uttarakhand.

“To do this, you need to visit the Census online portal. The portal is se.census.gov.in log in using your mobile number, enter your location, fill in the details regarding your family and submit the information,” he said.

The Prime Minister said the entire process takes about 15 to 20 minutes and for that no document is required to upload.

“After submitting the information, you will receive a special ID. You

can share this ID with the Census enumerator when they visit your home. After the information you provided is verified, it will become part of the Census record,” he said.

In his radio broadcast, the prime minister also spoke about protecting the environment and animals.

Modi said when people protect the environment, they do not merely save plants or animals; they strengthen that entire ecosystem.

He said some initiatives taking place in various parts of the country are

beautifully highlighting this sentiment.

Referring to the Sonai Rupai Wildlife Sanctuary in Assam, he said there was a time when elephants used to inhabit this area, but as human interference on forest land increased, the elephants moved away.

He said three years ago, this land was cleared of encroachment, and the results have been remarkable - the elephants have returned here again.

“Herds of elephants are once again being spotted in areas where they had not been active for years,” he said.

Modi said another wonderful initiative has taken place in Assam itself - this effort is to save a tiny creature, the Pygmy Hog.

“Once, its very existence was under threat; at that time, a conservation programme was launched with just six Pygmy Hogs, and they were reintroduced into the wild. Grasslands were also curated for their living. Today, thanks to this program, the Pygmy Hog population has risen to over 190,” he said.

The prime minister said the relationship of humans with nature is not limited merely to its preservation as often, when people care for nature, it becomes a source of sustenance for own lives.

He said in Sundarbans of West Bengal, some women are setting an inspiring example of this very bond and some women from Jharkhand are creating mangrove forests.

Shah flags off first LNG train

Says Prime Minister Modi transformed Railways while Congress indulged in scams during its tenure

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ahmedabad, September 27

Union minister Amit Shah on Sunday asserted that Prime Minister Narendra Modi had transformed the Railways, and asked the public to challenge the Congress, “which talks nonsense”, to a discussion on the basis of facts and figures.

Speaking at a gathering after flagging off the country’s first LNG train from Sabarmati station in Gujarat, Shah said the Congress did nothing apart from scams during its tenure, whereas “no one has been able to accuse Modi of corruption of even four annas in 12 years”.

“Before 2014, this country was ruled by one family. I want to talk only about railways. Dedicated freight corridor, rapid rail system, premium stations, all these have been started by Modiji. And by inaugurating a train



Amit Shah during the flagging-off ceremony of WAG-12 Locomotive Maintenance Shed PTI

running on hydrogen, he has placed India among just 4 countries in the world,” Shah said.

“The Congress speaks nonsense. The people of the country should ask them to discuss with figures. You (Congress) did nothing except fraud, scams and corruption worth Rs 12 lakh

crore. But no one has been able to accuse Modi of corruption of even four annas in 12 years,” the Union Home minister asserted.

During the programme, Shah also flagged off WAG-12 electric locomotive from Sabarmati station apart from dedicating to the nation, inaugurating and laying the foundation stones of major railway projects costing more than Rs 1,500 crore. Among these are line doubling works, the Kavach train protection system, automatic signalling system and a WAG-12 electric locomotive maintenance shed.

Shah said that the government has increased railway safety expenditure by 67 per cent and locomotive production capacity by 66 per cent during the tenure of the govt.

He said that the consumption of diesel by the Railways has decreased from 293 crore litres in 2015-16 to 108 crore litres in 2024-25.

Chhattisgarh CM hails PM’s praise for ‘Har Ghar Munga’ campaign

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Raipur, September 27

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai on Sunday welcomed Prime Minister Narendra Modi’s praise for Chhattisgarh’s ‘Har Ghar Munga’ nutrition campaign in his latest ‘Mann Ki Baat’ broadcast, and said the national recognition for the state’s initiatives is a matter of pride.

Addressing a gathering

in Kanker district, Sai urged citizens across Chhattisgarh to plant moringa saplings in their backyards and spread awareness about the plant’s nutritional benefits.

Sai listened to the 138th episode of Modi’s monthly radio programme at the Eklavya Model Residential School in Lamkanhar village of the Antagarh development block.

Modi, while highlighting September as Poshan

Maah, cited Chhattisgarh’s ‘Har Ghar Munga’ campaign, which aims to encourage people to include moringa, locally known as munga, in their daily diet and plant its saplings.

The chief minister said that ‘Mann Ki Baat’ provides a national platform for showcasing positive changes and innovations driven by public participation across the country.

Mayawati announces restructuring of BSP

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Lucknow, September 27

BSP supremo Mayawati on Sunday announced a restructuring of the party’s organisational set-up, dividing it into three sectors to strengthen its base among all sections of society.

In a post on X, Mayawati said sector one comprises 10 states and will be overseen by BSP Rajya Sabha members Ramji Gautam and Suresh Rao as central sector in-charges.

Sector two comprises nine states and has been assigned to former Rajya Sabha MP Rajaram and former MLA Atar Singh Rao as central sector in-charges, she said.

Uttar Pradesh and Uttarakhand have been placed under sector three and will be directly overseen by the party’s central camp office in Lucknow, Mayawati said.

Congress to hold ‘Dalit-Adivasi self-respect meet’ on Sep 29

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

The Congress SC/ST MPs’ Forum, along with the AICC departments for Scheduled Castes and Scheduled Tribes, will hold a Dalit-Adivasi Self-Respect Meeting at Constitution Club of India, on September 29.

The meeting will discuss the “purification” ritual conducted in Haldwani, Uttarakhand, after a public meeting addressed by Congress president and Leader of Opposition in the Rajya Sabha Mallikarjun Kharge.

MPs Mallu Ravi, Manoj Kumar, Tanuj Punia, Karamveer Baudh and Bhajan Lal Jatav spoke alongside Vikrant Bhuria, MLA and Chairman of the Adivasi Congress. They said the meet would also take up incidents of discrimination and violence against members of SC and ST communities.

Wangchuk backs Oct 2 CJP protest against CEC, may not attend

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

Activist Sonam Wangchuk on Sunday backed the Cockroach Janta Party’s proposed October 2 protest against Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar, saying efforts to improve accountability in the country and the electoral process deserved support.

While he expressed his support for CJP’s proposed agitation, Wangchuk added that he might not be physically present during the protest.

His comments came amid a row over the functioning of the Election Commission following an Indian Express report’s revelation that Election Commissioners S S Sandhu and Vivek Joshi objected on record at least 14 times over the past 10 months to decisions concerning voter registration,



Climate activist Sonam Wangchuk addresses a press conference, in New Delhi, Sunday PTI

deletions and restoration of names and the Special Intensive Revision of electoral rolls.

The Election Commission on Saturday asserted that all decisions relating to SIR received the unanimous approval of all three commissioners.

It also announced measures to assist voters facing notices during the revision, including home visits by Booth Level Officers in cases involving

unmapped electors and logical discrepancies, and said such people would generally not have to appear personally for hearings.

Wangchuk expressed his support for CJP’s proposed protest but said he did not need to physically participate in every movement. “Backing definitely, anything to improve accountability in the nation, always with them,” he said.

ELECTION COMMISSION’S FUNCTIONING

What Sandhu, Joshi flagged and how poll panel responded

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

The Election Commission of India has announced a series of decisions on issues that two election commissioners had raised in internal communications over the past 10 months, ranging from changes to voter registration forms to access to electoral roll databases and the functioning of its IT systems.

The decisions were taken at a meeting of Chief Election Commissioner Gyanesh Kumar and Election Commissioners Sukhbir Singh Sandhu and Vivek Joshi on Saturday.

The development comes

days after The Indian Express reported that Joshi and Sandhu had recorded objections on at least 14 occasions over a 10-month period to decisions and orders, some of which they said were issued without their knowledge.

Here are the key issues raised by the two commissioners and the Election Commission’s (EC) response or decision:

Changes to Form 6 Joshi objected to changes to Form 6, used for enrolling new voters, saying the statutory form prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, could not be modified without amending the

KEY POINTS

- » The decisions were taken at a meeting of CEC and Election Commissioners Sandhu and Joshi on Saturday
- » Joshi objected to changes to Form 6, used for enrolling new voters

Rules. Sandhu concurred with him.

After an SIR-related declaration was subsequently added to the online version of Form 6 on the Election Commission’s ECINET platform, Sandhu again objected, saying the statutory form had been altered without amending the relevant rules. He described the change as “unauthor-

ised/illegal” and sought its removal.

EC’s response: The commission said the additional declaration, which requires new voters to provide details of their own or their parents’ or grandparents’ entries in the electoral roll prepared during the previous SIR, had been upheld by the Supreme Court. It said the declara-

tion was specific to the SIR exercise and that, outside an SIR, the regular forms prescribed under the Registration of Electors Rules, 1960, would be used.

Access to electoral roll database

Sandhu and Joshi had raised concerns over centralisation of the electoral roll database and access to it available to statutory election authorities in states. Joshi proposed an audit to ensure that nobody other than statutory authorities had credentials to make changes to the database, while Sandhu questioned restrictions on access available to state officials.

EC’s response: The com-

mission said field officers have role-based access to ECINET according to their statutory powers. A committee headed by a senior deputy election commissioner and including an independent IIT or IIIT expert will review ECINET to “double-check” its compliance with election laws and rules.

Goa’s 97 voters

Following a Supreme Court order, electoral registration officers (EROs) in Goa examined cases of voters flagged for “logical discrepancies” and found 97 eligible for inclusion. However, according to the reported correspondence, the software did not have

an option to record the EROs’ decision and restore their names.

The Goa CEO’s office wrote eight times seeking a rollback option, but the voters remained outside the final roll.

EC’s response: The poll panel said BLOs have been directed to visit the left-out voters and collect their forms. Of the 97 voters, 81 have already filled Form 6 for inclusion. The EC has also decided that during the ongoing SIR, BLOs will visit voters issued notices for being unmapped or having logical discrepancies, collect their documents and upload them on ECINET for a decision by the ERO.

NDTV DEFENCE SUMMIT

Rajnath: India working on sixth-generation fighter jets

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

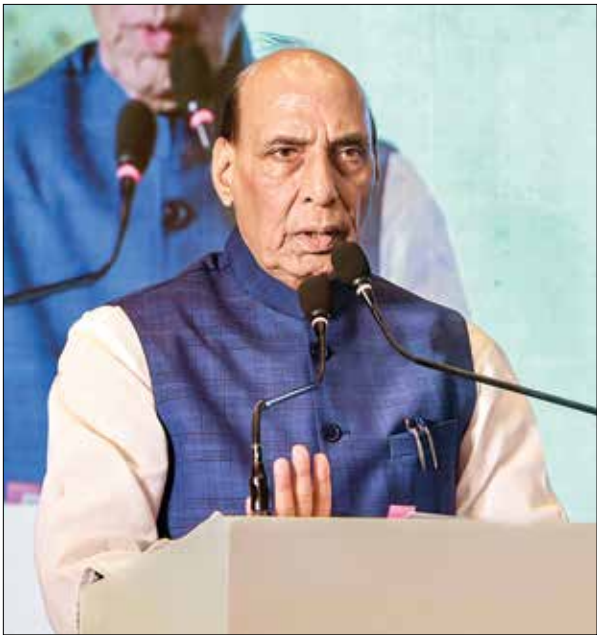
India is working towards developing sixth-generation fighter jets, and while there will be challenges along this path, the resolve remains unwavering, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh said on Sunday, asserting that the country is building capabilities with the warfare of the next two decades in mind.

In a veiled message to Pakistan, Singh also said that as long as “our neighbouring country persists with a state policy of terrorism, India remains fully free to carry out all forms of strikes against it”.

Singh was addressing a session at the NDTV Defence Summit, which was also attended by Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth and other senior officers of the armed forces.

“Today we are in the era of fifth-generation warfare, where, along with land, water and air, cyber, space and the human mind have also become new battlefields. The supply chains are also becoming a new ground of geopolitical conflict. New technologies like drones, artificial intelligence, quantum and hypersonic are changing the shape of the entire defence sector,” he said.

The defence minister underlined that today’s warfare is not merely a



Union Defence minister Rajnath Singh PTI

HIGHLIGHTS

- » Today we are in the era of fifth-generation warfare, where, along with land, water and air, cyber, space and the human mind have also become new battlefields
- » Today’s warfare is not merely a matter of soldier versus soldier; rather, it spans multiple domains, Singh said

matter of soldier versus soldier; rather, it spans multiple domains, including electronic warfare, information warfare, AI, drones, autonomous systems and precision weapons.

“We recognise that the future landscape of security and the battlefield will be technology-driven.

So the nation that leads in technology will hold an advantage on the battlefield. That is why we have emphasised making India’s defence strategy future-ready; our focus today extends beyond the weapons of the present,” he said.

“We are building capabilities with the warfare of

the next 10 to 20-25 years in mind. We want India not merely to import technology, but to define it,” Singh said.

On India’s position in the world order, Singh said, “India is neither a status quoist power nor a revisionist power. I believe we are a civilisational power.

“The objective of our rise is not to leave another country behind or to dismantle the existing order; rather, it is about collective and inclusive growth. Our goal is - rise without rupture, positive change without conflict,” Singh emphasised.

“We envision a world where India advances, and the entire world moves forward alongside us,” he added.

The minister underlined that India believes in peace and does not seek to occupy the territory of any country.

“However, peace should not be mistaken for weakness,” Singh said.

“We seek global stability, but not at the cost of our strategic autonomy. We are firmly committed to safeguarding our security and strategic autonomy when threatened,” he said.

India believes in dialogue. However, if a country fuels terrorism against India, the “scope for dialogue ceases to exist”, the defence minister said.

Manipur peace requires community dialogue, not military force: Kiren Rijiju

Surrender arms, and peace will automatically come, says minister

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

Union minister Kiren Rijiju on Sunday said the warring communities in Manipur must talk to each other to ensure permanent peace in the troubled state, as the Centre cannot use the military to end the conflict, which has been going on intermittently for more than three years.

Addressing a conclave organised by the Assam-based Pratidin Media Network here, Rijiju also said that “humiliation and insult” towards small communities by successive governments since Independence led to the formation of a large number of militant groups in the Northeast.

Sharing his own experience of facing humil-



Kiren Rijiju addresses the opening ceremony of ‘The Conclave 2026’, in New Delhi PTI

iation at the hands of then-Union Home minister S B Chavan in the 1990s - when he and other students went to meet him as part of a student delegation - Rijiju said Chavan even insulted then-Union minister of state P K Thungon for accompanying the students, terming them

“gunda” (rowdies).

Talking about the ongoing conflict in Manipur, the minister for parliamentary and minority affairs said the Meitei and Kuki communities, as well as the Naga and Kuki communities, must talk to each other to find an amicable solution.

“I have a simple formula. Surrender arms, and peace will automatically come. We cannot use the military because its side effects are huge. The groups should talk to each other. There should be dialogue. A solution will come through talks, and only then will peace prevail,” he said.

Rijiju said everyone should appeal to the fighting groups to abjure violence and surrender arms; there can be no develop-

ment without peace, he said.

There was a time when even the most junior officer of the Central government was always dismissive of the problems faced by the small communities in the Northeast and would sometimes not even grant an appointment, Rijiju said.

“Frustrated by such behaviour, many groups went back to their homes in the Northeast, took up arms, and engaged in violence,” he said.

The minister asserted that no one can support or validate militants taking up arms, as there can be no justification for such acts in a democracy.

“But we have to see why they took up arms,” he said.

Under construction building collapses near Ambala City, four dead, over 10 injured

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Ambala, September 27

Four people died while more than ten were injured when a three-storeyed building under construction collapsed at Dhulkot village near Ambala City on Sunday, officials said.

The incident unfolded in the late afternoon when the concrete slab (lintel) for the roof was being cast on the first floor, prompting locals to initiate rescue efforts before informing the police

and emergency services.

One of the injured workers claimed that some labourers were working on the ground floor, while others were engaged in the casting work above.

Ambala Civil Surgeon Renu Beri told reporters that 12 injured labourers were brought to the hospital, of whom five are still admitted, two were discharged on request, while the others were discharged after first aid was applied.

“Four were brought dead to the civil hospital in the evening. Their bodies have been shifted to the mortuary,” she further said.

Talking to reporters in the evening, Ambala’s Superintendent of Police, Ajit Singh Shekhawat, confirmed that four people had died in the incident.

NDRF, State Disaster Response Force, police and civil administration teams were engaged in the rescue operations after the inci-

dent, he said.

When asked if more people were trapped under the debris, the SP said, “Two to three people have been located, and efforts are on to rescue them.”

Police and senior administrative officials immediately arrived at the site with rescue equipment and engaged in removing debris.

An official said that heavy earth-moving machines and other machinery were pressed into service.

Briefs

CRPF man shoots himself dead

RANCHI: A CRPF personnel died after allegedly sustaining a gunshot injury from his service rifle while on duty at a camp in Ranchi on Sunday, police said.

The incident occurred at the CRPF camp in Tiril in the Vidhan Sabha police station area, they said.

Digital arrest case: 2 more held

NEW DELHI: The CBI has arrested two more accused, and launched searches at 22 locations across 10 states as part of its nationwide probe into digital arrest frauds under operation Chakra-VI.

The CBI continues investigating the alleged case of ‘digital arrest’ of a victim through impersonation of police officer and officials of TRAI.

Char Dham Yatra suspended

DEHRADUN: The Char Dham Yatra in Uttarakhand remained suspended for the second consecutive day on Sunday due to incessant heavy rain, while two people, including a child, died in separate rain-related incidents, officials said.

Around 136 mountaineers were stranded at various locations in the state’s mountainous regions due to heavy snowfall.

ANTI-SACRILEGE ACT Mann meets 7-member panel to deliberate on amendments

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 27

Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann on Sunday reiterated that Sri Akal Takht Sahib is supreme for all of us and that his government will leave no stone unturned to protect the sanctity and dignity of Sri Guru Granth Sahib Ji through the strongest possible legal framework against beadbi.

At a detailed meeting with the seven-member high-level committee constituted by the state government, the Chief Minister emphasised that life imprisonment and heavy fines for those who commit beadbi form the core foundation of the law and cannot be diluted.

The meeting, held at the Chief Minister’s residence, focused on the provisions of the Jaagat Jot Sri

Guru Granth Sahib Satkar (Amendment) Act, 2026, concerns raised regarding certain provisions and the way forward through consultation and consensus.

He directed the committee to hold detailed and regular meetings with the panel constituted by Sri Akal Takht Sahib to review the proposed amendments, consider its suggestions and evolve consensus, while ensuring that the law continues to provide the strongest possible protection to the sanctity of Sri Guru Granth Sahib and brings solace to the deeply hurt sentiments of the Sikh Sangat.

The Chief Minister pointed out, “There is no doubt that this law has provided solace to the deeply hurt sentiments of the Sikh Sangat, which has been perturbed over frequent incidents of sacrilege.

ED attaches Rs 442 crore assets in money laundering case

OUR CORRESPONDENT
Bengaluru, September 27

The Directorate of Enforcement (ED), Bengaluru Zonal Office, has provisionally attached movable and immovable assets worth approximately Rs 442.35 crore in the RummyCulture App and other online real-money gaming case registered under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA), 2002.

The ED issued the Provisional Attachment Order (PAO) on September 25 under section 5(I) of the PMLA.

The property attached includes fixed deposit balances, commercial shops, villa and residential properties in the names of family members, private family trusts and associated entities of the shareholders of Gameskraft Technologies Pvt. Ltd.

Oppn should present facts before questioning EC, says CM Saini

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 27

Haryana Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini said that the need of the hour in the country is not the politics of allegations, but the politics of facts.

He said that in a democracy, the Opposition has every right to oppose the government, raise questions and seek answers, but such questions should be based on facts, and if allegations are levelled against any constitutional institution, there should be concrete evidence to substantiate them.

He said that constitutional institutions such as the Election Commission, the Supreme Court and the Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) are not institutions belonging to any particular government or political party. Their prestige and credibility are an asset of the entire country and its democratic system. Therefore, despite politi-



Chief Minister Nayab Singh Saini seeks blessings during the Hanuman Katha organised in Ludhiana MPOST

cal differences, maintaining the dignity of these institutions is the collective responsibility of all political parties and citizens.

The Chief Minister was addressing a press conference organised in Gurugram on Sunday.

Haryana Industries and Commerce Minister Rao Narbir Singh, Sohna MLA, Tejpal Tanwar, Pataudi MLA, Bimla Chaudhary and Media Advisor to Chief Minister, Rajeev Jaitly were

also present.

The Chief Minister said that in recent times, questions have been raised by the Congress and its allied parties regarding the Election Commission, the electoral process and other constitutional institutions.

He said that questioning the functioning of any institution may be part of democracy, but making serious allegations without evidence is not appropriate.

Paddy, Bajra not being procured in mandis: Hooda

MPOST BUREAU
Chandigarh, September 27



Former Chief Minister and Leader of the Opposition Bhupinder Singh Hooda has demanded the immediate commencement of paddy procurement.

He said while the arrival of paddy and Bajra is in full swing at the mandis, the failure to start government procurement is forcing farmers to sell their crops at rates up to Rs 400 per quintal lower than expected.

“Farmers are being deprived not only of the Minimum Support Price (MSP) but also of basic amenities in the mandis. The govt has not made proper arrangements for storing the crop, no weighing scales, and no provisions made for lifting or handling the produce. To make matters worse, the government has once again imposed limits, forcing farmers to endure long waits,” he said.

Hooda addressed the public today in the villages of Nandal, Chiri, Katwara, Khidwali, Ghuskani, Jindran, and Titaili in his constituency.

Upon his arrival, people accorded him a rousing welcome and pledged their full support for the upcoming struggle against the BJP.

Hooda expressed his gratitude to everyone and affirmed that this struggle would certainly yield results.

First scientific record of Sistan sand boas in India

Its a non-venomous, thick-bodied snake found in dry areas earlier known to be from Iran, Pak

OUR CORRESPONDENT
New Delhi, September 27

A snake species known as the Sistan sand boa has been scientifically recorded in India for the first time after researchers found three of them in Rajasthan’s Sikar district.

The Sistan sand boa (Eryx sistanensis) is a non-venomous, thick-bodied snake found in dry areas. It was earlier known to be from Iran and Pakistan.

Researchers Vivek Sharma of Jabalpur and wildlife biologist Dhar-



mendra Khandal of Ranthambhore-based Tiger Watch found three of these snakes during a survey in the Ramgarh-Shekhawati

area of Sikar in 2025.

Their study was published in the Journal of Threatened Taxa on May 26 this year. The first snake

KEY POINTS

- » The first snake was found inside a gaushala on August 19, 2025. Another was found in the courtyard of a house at Sunda Ki Dhani on September 12 and the third near an under-construction house at Rukansar on September 21 last year
- » The researchers studied their body shape, colour and scales before identifying them as Sistan sand boas

was found inside a gaushala on August 19, 2025. Another was found in the courtyard of a house at Sunda Ki Dhani on September 12 and the third near an under-construction house

at Rukansar on September 21 last year.

The researchers studied their body shape, colour and scales before identifying them as Sistan sand boas. “We knew that this

snake was different, but we did not rush to publish a research paper. We first decided to understand and study it properly,” Khandal said. The Sistan sand boa looks similar to the red sand boa commonly known in India. One of the easier ways to tell them apart is their tails.

The Sistan sand boa’s tail gradually becomes thinner and ends in a pointed tip. The red sand boa’s tail remains thick for much of its length before narrowing towards the end, according to the study.

EDITORIAL

Beyond Technical Fixes

The latest software problem identified in Boeing’s 737 MAX is troubling because of where and when the flaw can surface. It affects automated flight guidance after a missed approach: if pilots abandon a landing and then alter the programmed flight path, vertical navigation can disengage and the aircraft may revert to simpler automation. Pilots are trained to handle such situations and Boeing maintains that the issue does not constitute a safety concern. Yet a go-around is a demanding phase in which crews should not encounter an unexpected reduction in automation. Boeing informed operators in August and is developing a permanent software update, while the US Federal Aviation Administration is reviewing the matter. That response is necessary, but reassurance cannot substitute for scrutiny. Aviation safety rests not on assuming trained crews will compensate for technical weaknesses, but on ensuring systems behave predictably when workload is already high.

The problem also carries a burden of history. The 737 MAX programme cannot be viewed like an aircraft family with an unblemished record. The crashes of Lion Air Flight 610 in 2018 and Ethiopian Airlines Flight 302 in 2019, which together killed 346 people, exposed failures involving design, certification and assumptions about pilot response. The MAX subsequently underwent changes and regulatory review before returning to service. That history does not mean every new defect proves the aircraft unsafe; complex machines can develop faults, and identifying them is part of aviation safety. But Boeing and regulators must meet a high standard of transparency. Reports that major US carriers have sought deliveries without the affected software underline the need for clarity over which aircraft carry it and what interim procedures crews must follow. For India, the question is relevant because Air India Express and Akasa Air together operate around 96 MAX aircraft.

The larger lesson extends beyond Boeing. Modern commercial aircraft are increasingly software-dependent, and certification regimes must evolve accordingly. A software update cannot be treated as routine merely because no physical component has changed. Alterations to flight-management logic can interact with pilot inputs, automation modes and unusual circumstances in ways that emerge only under particular conditions. Regulators therefore need rigorous testing not merely of what software is designed to do, but of how it fails, how pilots recognise failure and how quickly they can recover. The FAA’s review should establish whether interim instructions are sufficient and whether further action is required. Boeing, meanwhile, should move quickly on the permanent fix and communicate openly with operators. The objective should neither be to dramatise every software bug nor minimise one because pilots can work around it. In aviation, redundancy and training are safeguards, not excuses for avoidable defects. The MAX has already demonstrated the terrible cost of allowing assumptions to outrun engineering caution. Its future credibility will depend on showing that every warning, however narrow its circumstances, is investigated with the seriousness it deserves.

LETTER



letter2editor.mp@gmail.com.

Rumours Fuel Unrest

The suspension of academic activities at Chitkara University following student protests is concerning. Authorities must urgently address the rumours surrounding the alleged suicides through transparent communication and verified information. Students, too, must exercise restraint and reject violence. Universities must ensure credible grievance mechanisms so that uncertainty does not escalate into dangerous unrest.

GURLEEN KAUR,
RAJPURA

You can also send your comments to The Editor, Millennium Post, Pratap Bhawan, 5 Bahadur Shah Zafar Marg, New Delhi 110 002

Faith, Service and Nation

Ashok Singhal’s life has brought together spiritual conviction, organisational discipline and an abiding commitment to service, social unity and cultural renewal

ENDURING LEGACY



NARENDRA MODI

THE WRITER IS THE PRIME MINISTER OF INDIA

There is a beautiful saying, “वृक्ष कबहुँ नहि फल भखे, नदी न संचौ नीर। परमार्थ के कारणे, साधुन धरा शरीर।” It means the tree does not consume its own fruit, nor does the river retain its waters. Both exist for the benefit of others. Our saints and seers have long taught us that a life devoted to the welfare of those around us acquires a meaning far greater than individual achievement. If there is one person in whom this spirit was constantly reflected, it was Shri Ashok Singhal Ji.

Starting 27th September, we mark his birth centenary to celebrate an outstanding personality who brought together spiritual pursuit, cultural awakening and decades of dedicated organisational work.

I consider it a privilege that I had innumerable opportunities to interact with Ashok Ji and receive his affection. One of the earliest instances dates back to 1981, when I was a young Karyakarta going about the organisational duties given to me. I received a handwritten letter from him. Naturally, it was a noteworthy moment for me. He talked about an important upcoming programme and gave

a few tasks to be done.

Over several decades, I saw him work day and night. He would undertake long and often difficult travels to the remotest of areas. He was particularly passionate about travelling across tribal areas of Gujarat. His mind was constantly running, thinking about what more one can do for those on the margins of society. Whenever any part of the nation was affected by a natural disaster, Ashok Ji was either among the first to reach there himself or among those guiding Karyakartas to help those affected. My own experience with him in the aftermath of the 2001 Kutch earthquake was unforgettable.

This spirit of compassion and care for others is something that came to Ashok Ji very early in his life. He hailed from a very illustrious and prosperous family. His father, Shri Mahavir Ji, was a distinguished administrator. One of his brothers, Shri BP Singhal Ji, went on to become a police officer and later a Member of Parliament. Another brother, Shri VP Singhal Ji, was the Chief Secretary of Tripura when the state was just formed. Other family members succeeded in the world of commerce and agriculture. But from a young age, Ashok Ji was attracted to something else altogether...the revival of Bharat and bringing glory to Maa Bharti’s children. Growing up in Prayagraj, Ashok Ji would sit for hours on the banks of the Sangam. The river naturally interested him, but so did the people who came, such as saints, seers and devotees. It nurtured an understanding of India’s cultural ethos and strengthened his intention to do something for society. This desire to live for others drew him to the RSS. He embraced every responsibility that came his way with enthusiasm, discipline and a sense of duty.

Shri Ashok Singhal Ji nurtured institutions and movements through persistence and hard work. He was blessed with a



Singhal believed individual purpose acquired meaning when placed at society’s service

FROM PRAYAGRAJ TO AYODHYA, A LIFETIME OF ORGANISATION AND OUTREACH LEFT AN ENDURING PUBLIC LEGACY

formidable voice and an oratory that could hold an entire gathering in its spell. Equally noteworthy was his care for fellow Karyakartas. Anyone who came into contact with him could not help but marvel at his remarkable simplicity. He shared a deep bond with the Sant Samaj and commanded immense respect among saints and seers across the country. They valued his counsel and listened to him with great regard.

My mind goes back to two instances which brought out the legendary persona of Shri Ashok Singhal Ji. The first was in 1993, when the Vishwa Hindu Parishad organised a convention in the USA to mark 100 years since Swami Vivekananda’s Chicago address. The vision to host

such a conference overseas, the planning and the bringing together of diverse stakeholders revealed the organisational genius of Ashok Ji.

The second instance is from the year 2000. The World Hindu Conference was organised in Port of Spain in Trinidad and Tobago. I could see how his presence ignited so much enthusiasm among other delegates. After my address, his words of appreciation were a very moving experience for me. I saw yet again how his encouragement filled every Karyakarta with so much energy.

No mention of Shri Ashok Singhal Ji is complete without recalling his pivotal role in the Ram Janmabhoomi Movement. Who can forget his address at the Boat Club Rally in 1991? Or the defining image of an injured and bleeding Ashok Ji at the peak of the movement. Today, if there is a grand Ram Mandir in Ayodhya, it is because of stalwarts like him who selflessly immersed themselves in the effort to make it possible. He would have been the happiest person on seeing the Ram Mandir take shape in Ayodhya.

Shri Ashok Singhal Ji was blessed with remarkable clarity of thought and one area

where it was clearly seen was his belief that our society needs to be harmonious, that the message of brotherhood has to be reaffirmed. He worked towards strengthening social unity and equality. He firmly believed that there could be no distinction of any kind in society and that every individual deserved equal dignity and respect. It was his thought that the first brick of the Ram Mandir in Ayodhya would be laid by Shri Kameshwar Choupal Ji, a grassroots VHP Karyakarta from Bihar who hailed from the marginalised sections of society. At a Dharm Sansad in Kashi, he decided that the Dom Raja would be honoured and went on to work with him as part of various community efforts.

Beyond nation-building, Shri Ashok Singhal Ji had two areas that were very close to his heart: education (especially Vedic education) and music. As the MP from Varanasi, I feel very proud that the city I represent, the eternal Kashi, has played its part in Shri Ashok Singhal Ji’s life. He was educated at BHU and was also known to be a good student. He was closely associated with the Ekal Vidyalaya initiative, which worked to extend basic education to remote villages, especially among tribal communities. He was a voracious reader as well as a good listener and he always told younger Karyakartas to read as much as possible.

Those who knew Ashok Ji closely knew how well he sang! I recall meetings in Nagpur, where he would sing the Ekal Geet, leaving everyone mesmerised and setting the tone for the meeting. A video of him surprising everyone and singing “हे मातृभूमि मेरी, हे विभूभूमि मेरी” during his 90th birthday celebrations in 2015 went viral.

On his birth centenary, let us ensure that more youngsters know about his greatness. And let us renew our pledge to realise his dreams for our nation and our people.

Defiance amid Deepening Isolation

Netanyahu’s combative UN address had sought to answer Israel’s critics, but the walkout reflected the diplomatic pressures gathering around his government

GLOBAL FAULTLINES



ASIF ULLAH KHAN

THE WRITER IS A SENIOR JOURNALIST

If there are any other moral cowards who haven’t yet left this hall, please do so now.” This is how Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu opened his speech at the UN General Assembly as delegates started emptying the hall.

It was the outburst of a man who has been isolated – both at home and abroad. Even before Netanyahu took the plane to New York, with very few places he could go due to the ICC arrest warrant, he was aware of the kind of reception awaiting him. New York Mayor Zohran Mamdani was calling for his arrest, and for more than a week, Americans, including Jews, were demonstrating against him outside the

General Assembly. This was a very different reception from what an Israeli prime minister usually gets in New York, supposedly the most Jewish city in the US.

Inside the Assembly hall, the beleaguered prime minister’s performance was far below par as he unsuccessfully tried to defend the indefensible. He called the Gaza genocide a “lie of the century”, dismissing the settlers’ violence against Palestinians in the West Bank as the work of 150 juvenile delinquents. Keeping an eye on the general election, which is just 33 days away, Netanyahu delivered an election speech aimed at an audience that many of his supporters wanted him to address. However, the combative speech about ‘us’ and ‘others’ failed to resonate with the domestic audience. Although his supporters praised him for confronting international criticism, his critics argued that Netanyahu spent too much of the speech attacking Israel’s critics and missed an opportunity to present a more detailed case about Iran and Israel’s international position.

Former prime minister Naftali Bennett accused him of missing “a historic opportunity to declare Qatar an enemy state”, while Palestinian-Israeli politician Ahmad Tibi mocked him, posting a video of delegates leaving the room at the start of his speech. “‘Voluntary migration’ from the hall: yet another international achievement for Netanyahu,” he posted



The walkout offered a visual measure of mounting opposition to Israeli policies

ISRAEL NOW CONFRONTS DISCONTENT ABROAD ALONGSIDE INCREASINGLY CONTENTIOUS DEBATES AT HOME

on X, mocking a euphemism for expelling Palestinians from their land that is backed by many right-wing Israeli politicians.

Ahron Bregman, an Israeli security analyst and senior teaching fellow at King’s College London, was more scathing, calling him toxic and saying that he has turned Israel into a pariah state. He said: “His speech was littered with lies. He played down the settlers’ violence in the West Bank, saying that just a few Palestinians were killed by it, while in reality more than 80 were killed [by Israeli forces and settlers] there this year.” He is a brilliant orator but a serial liar, Bregman added.

Left-leaning Haaretz and centre-left Yedioth Ahro-noth strongly criticised the address, saying that Netanyahu’s remarks were filled with

threats and accusations but failed to conceal the fundamental void at its core. They said the speech offered no clear vision for peace, an end to the war or a defined future for Israel, and that the empty seats in the hall underscored the country’s growing diplomatic isolation.

The most worrying factor for the average Israeli is the growing isolation in the US. Netanyahu’s combative performance at the UN cannot conceal a seismic change taking place in the US. Recent Pew Research Center surveys show that public support for Israel in the US has reached record lows, with roughly 60 per cent of American adults expressing an unfavourable view of the country. This is the reason why Democratic nominees opposed to Israeli policies in Gaza and AIPAC’s political influence have won primaries despite enormous outside spending. The presence of prominent Hollywood figures, including Susan Sarandon and Hannah Einbinder, who joined pro-Palestinian protesters as Netanyahu spoke at the UN, shows how the Palestinian issue has entered mainstream American cultural politics.

With Netanyahu’s ratings falling sharply in the US, especially among young Americans, any loud or combative speech is unlikely to reverse this trend. The UN event – both inside and outside – showed just how out of sync he is with reality: Israel is losing friends thick and fast.

Views expressed are personal

News at a glance

Azerbaijani woman ‘gangraped’ in Lahore

LAHORE: A 20-year-old Azerbaijani woman was allegedly gang-raped by three men after being taken to a flat in Lahore's Defence Housing Authority area, police said on Sunday. The woman, who arrived from Baku more than two weeks ago for business and was staying in Raiwind, was allegedly taken to a cafe by two women on September 25. Police said three men later took her to a flat, where she was allegedly drugged and assaulted. She was abandoned near Ghazi Interchange and her iPhone allegedly stolen.

SL police remove statue of banned LTTE leader

COLOMBO: Sri Lankan police on Sunday removed a statue of banned LTTE leader Rasiah Parthipan, alias Thilleepan, from Nallur in Jaffna, officials said. Police spokesman F T Wootler said the bronze statue was removed following a complaint over the commemoration of a member of a proscribed organisation. Thilleepan, regarded as a symbol of Tamil resistance, died on September 26, 1987, after a 10-day hunger strike. The LTTE remains banned in Sri Lanka and several countries, including India.

Nepal: 12 missing in avalanche

KATHMANDU: Twelve people, including climbers, went missing on Sunday after an avalanche struck the Himlung Himal peak in Nepal's Manang district, police said. The avalanche at the base camp of the 7,126 metre Himlung Himal peak in the Nar Phu area buried a tent where nine climbers and 13 support staff, were taking shelter. Around a dozen people are missing after the incident, said Deputy Superintendent of Police of the Armed Police Force Shailendra Thapa. Some human casualties are also feared in the incident, Thapa said, highlighting that all those missing are Nepali nationals.

RAF base threat: Counter-terror police lead probe

LONDON: The UK's counter-terror police said it is leading an investigation after five men were arrested on suspicion of terror offences near a Royal Air Force (RAF) base in a UK village on Sunday. The Metropolitan Police said armed officers responded after the local police unit received a call at 0045 local time relating to three suspicious vehicles, which appeared to be travelling towards RAF Fairford in south-west England. The men were arrested in the Whelford area of Gloucestershire on suspicion of committing offences under the UK Explosives Act.

SEARCH ON FOR MULTIPLE SUSPECTS

S Africa: Separate mass shootings in townships leave at least 27 dead

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Cape Town, September 27

Eight gunmen with AK-47 rifles and pistols opened fire at patrons at a bar in the first of two separate mass shootings in South African townships in the space of a few hours that left at least 27 people dead, police said Sunday. The first massacre occurred late Saturday night near Johannesburg. The second happened in the early hours of Sunday near Cape Town. No arrests had been made in the two shootings, which came just five days after another mass shooting in a township near the city of Durban killed at least 11 people. The South African Police Service said 17 people were killed Saturday night when eight suspects armed with AK-47 rifles and pistols opened fire at a bar in Wedela township, southwest of South Africa's biggest city of Johannesburg, around 9.30 pm. The suspects shot at patrons outside the bar, then moved inside to continue the killing. The victims included 13 men and four women. At least 15 others sustained gunshot injuries, according to



A South African police personnel at a shooting site

CLOSER LOOK

- » The first massacre occurred late Saturday night near Johannesburg while the second incident happened in the early hours of Sunday near Cape Town
- » On Tuesday night, 11 people were killed, including a pregnant woman, in an attack by multiple gunmen at a house party in KwaMakhutha township south of Durban

police, who said the gunmen searched some of the patrons and took their mobile phones before escaping in two vehicles. Around four hours later, 10 people were killed and 11 were wounded in a mass

shooting after 1 am at a store in Lwandle township near Cape Town, South Africa's second biggest city. Police said they were searching for multiple suspects, though they didn't give an exact number. On Tuesday night, 11 people were killed, including a pregnant woman, in an attack by multiple gunmen at a house party in KwaMakhutha township south of Durban. Police have not reported any arrests. South Africa has struggled with high rates of violent crime for years, but the series of mass shootings this week were shocking even to a country used to some of the highest homicide rates in the world. A high rate of killings is a longstanding problem for

Africa's most advanced economy, but the phenomenon of mass shootings is becoming more common, according to experts, with recent killings often being carried out by multiple gunmen. The homicides mostly affect South Africa's poorest communities and police have linked some to criminal gangs. Other recent mass shootings include one in June in a poor neighbourhood of Johannesburg that killed 12 people, and two in the space of two weeks in December that left a total of 21 people dead. South Africa's violent crime problem prompted President Cyril Ramaphosa to deploy soldiers on the streets in March in a year-long operation to combat crime in some of the country's worst-affected areas. The deployment included high-crime areas around Johannesburg and Cape Town, as well as other areas. Announcing the deployment, Ramaphosa said crime by organised gangs was the biggest threat to South Africa's democracy and economic development. Some critics viewed the use of soldiers on the streets as an admission that police were failing. Strikes across Ukraine killed at least six people overnight and on Sunday, officials said, hours after Moscow rejected German calls to ease off its escalation toward NATO. Russia's top diplomat on Saturday brushed off what's believed to have been the first face-to-face meeting with his German counterpart since Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine in 2022. The meeting was held during the UN General Assembly's annual gathering of world leaders, as an intensifying aerial war between Russia and Ukraine showed no sign of slowing. Ties between Russia and Germany have soured in recent weeks, following an attempted drone attack last month at Leipzig airport that Berlin blamed on the Kremlin. With front-line positions largely unchanged since last year, Moscow has hammered its neighbour with cruise and ballistic missiles, powerful glide bombs and jet-powered drones in recent months. Meanwhile, Kyiv's long-range drones have targeted Russian oil refineries and businesses. Russian and Ukrainian strikes kill 6 In Kyiv, a man was found dead after a Russian drone hit a non-residential building overnight, accord-



ing to Ukraine's emergency service. Later on Sunday, Russian drone strikes killed one person and wounded at least five on the outskirts of Kyiv, according to local administration head Tymur Tkachenko. One person died and four were wounded in Vyshneve, where a drone damaged five vehicles and caused a blaze, Tkachenko said. A security guard at a window manufacturing facility was also injured near the town of Fastiv, he added. In Russian-occupied Ukraine, a strike by Kyiv's forces on Sunday killed a civilian woman in Enerhodar, the town housing Europe's largest nuclear plant, according to its Kremlin-installed mayor. Maxim Pukhov said the Ukrainian drones also wounded two others. Russian forces also attacked Ukraine's southern Odesa region, which surrounds the country's main Black Sea port, multiple times overnight into Sunday, killing one person and injuring two others, according to the head of the local military administration, Oleh Kiper. On Sunday afternoon, a woman and a 16-year-old girl were killed as Russian guided bombs struck the city of Sumy in northern Ukraine, regional administration head Oleh Hryhorov reported. He said five other people were wounded. Separately, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy said Russia struck twice at a data centre in Kyiv on Sunday morning, injuring two children and an adult. Russia's Defence Ministry said the data centre was providing internet services to Ukraine's armed forces. Russia and Ukraine have repeatedly blamed each other for damaging power lines supplying Enerhodar's Zaporizhzhia nuclear power plant, which Moscow captured early in the war. The plant is not in service, but needs power to keep cooling systems running and maintain safety.

Briefs

USTR to host G20 trade ministers

WASHINGTON: US Trade Representative (USTR) Jamieson Greer will host a meeting of trade and commerce ministers of G20 countries in Milwaukee from September 29 to October 1, amid constant changes in US tariff policies and the challenges posed by the extended Iran war and the pressure on supply chains.

Pak to host meet of SCO coordinators

ISLAMABAD: Pakistan will host a three-day meeting of national coordinators of the SCO from Monday as it begins preparations for the grouping's Council of Heads of State summit in August 2027. The meeting, to be held from September 28 to 30, marks an important initial engagement under Pakistan's chairmanship of the SCO Council of Heads of State for 2026-27.

Congo boat mishap: 12 dead, dozens missing

Vessel capsizes in Lake Kivu

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Bukavu, September 27

A vessel carrying traders capsized in Lake Kivu in eastern Congo, killing at least 12 and leaving dozens missing, authorities said Sunday. The vessel was carrying more than 50 people when it capsized on Saturday night on Idjwi Island, in South Kivu province, said Félix Habiragi, chief of the village of Kisheke near the scene of the accident.

He said that about 15 people have been rescued. The cause of the accident was not immediately clear, he added. Deadly boat accidents are common in Congo, where rivers and lakes are a major means of transport for its more than 100 million people. The vessel was transporting fish traders and goods from Idjwi Island's Bwina to Boza, according to Muhindo Ntambuka Pascal, the local administrator. The Palestinian death toll from the nearly three-year Israel-Hamas war has surpassed 74,000, according to Gaza's Health Ministry. While a ceasefire that took effect last Oct. 10 has halted the heaviest fighting, Israeli strikes have continued in what the military has said are responses to threats or attacks. Gaza ceasefire remains largely stalled. Gaza's Health Ministry on Saturday said the Palestinian death toll has risen to 74,016 people, with 175,068 wounded. The war

Gaza war: Palestinian death toll surpasses 74K

ASSOCIATED PRESS
Dubai, September 27

ISRAELI STRIKES HAVE CONTINUED IN WHAT THE MILITARY HAS SAID ARE RESPONSES TO THREATS OR ATTACKS

erupted on Oct. 7, 2023, when Hamas-led militants invaded Israel, killing some 1,200 people, mostly civilians, and taking 251 others hostage. Since the ceasefire, 1,145 Palestinians have been killed, said the ministry, which is part of the Hamas-led government. It maintains detailed records viewed as generally reliable by UN agencies and international organisations. It does not distinguish between civilians and militants, but says women and children make up around half the toll. Meanwhile, seven Israeli soldiers have been killed since the ceasefire. Other aspects of the US-brokered ceasefire remain largely stalled. Israeli forces now control over half of the Palestinian territory, Hamas has not disarmed, a new Palestinian government has not arrived and reconstruction

has not yet begun. Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu says Israeli forces will not withdraw until Hamas disarms. Israel's Jewish opposition vows cooperation to beat Netanyahu. Israel's leading Jewish opposition parties promised to join efforts to beat Netanyahu's coalition in next month's "critical elections," in a statement Saturday evening. The parties have been criticised for infighting. The vote, the first since the Oct. 7, 2023, attacks, is largely seen as a referendum on the security failures that led to the attacks.

China: Mine waste dumping damages section of iconic 'Great Wall'

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
Beijing, September 27

A remote section of China's iconic Great Wall was damaged by 20 years of mine waste dumping, official media reported on Sunday. The ancient stones of a remote Ming-era stretch of the structure in northern central China have been sacrificed for cheaper dumping of coal-mining waste, state-run CCTV reported. For nearly 20 years, a section of the wall in Ningwu county, Shanxi province, was used as a shortcut to dump slag, despite whistleblowers repeatedly raising the alarm to officials, the Hong Kong-based South China Morning Post quoted from the CCTV report. The damage to the Great Wall's Guojia Yao section began in 2007, when an unlicensed miner, Ningwu Chaokai Coal Industry, dug a trench through the structure to dispose of excavation waste, the report said. CCTV said that local authorities did not respond to repeated reports by whistleblowers that started in 2015, allowing the vandalism to persist for nearly two decades and leaving a six-metre (19-foot) gap in the wall.

SMALL BITES FROM THE UN

Canada's wider view & Iceland's reframing of Netanyahu's words

ASSOCIATED PRESS
United Nations, September 27

China and Russia got their turns to speak at the United Nations on Saturday, but that wasn't all. Watchers from across the globe could find news that affected their lives at the UN General Assembly meetings.

Here are a few moments: **Redefining Netanyahu's words** The foreign minister of Iceland, Thorgerdur Katrin Gunnarsdottir, used part of her time on the world stage



Saturday to turn Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's words on Friday upside down. Netanyahu, addressing people who were walking out on his remarks, called them "moral cowards." A day later, Gunnarsdottir was having none of it. Speaking about Gaza, she said: "We have heard the words moral cowards' from this podium. To me, moral

KEY POINTS

- » China and Russia got their turns to speak at the United Nations on Saturday, but that wasn't all
- » The foreign minister of Iceland, Thorgerdur Katrin Gunnarsdottir, used part of her time on the world stage Saturday to turn Israeli Prime Minister Benjamin Netanyahu's words on Friday upside down

cowards are those leaders around the world who refuse to sit down and negotiate a just and lasting peace. Those who deny access to humanitarian aid for people in desperate need. And moral

cowards are those leaders who repeatedly go against and disrespect international law." **In diplomacy, Canada looks past the usual horizon**

News at a glance

Tata Motors PV eyes 15% mkt share very soon, 20% by FY31

NEW DELHI: Tata Motors Passenger Vehicles expects to cross 15 per cent domestic market share very soon and remains committed to reaching 20 per cent by FY31, MD and CEO Shailesh Chandra said.

The nearly year-old standalone business has grown nearly 40 per cent over the past year & is exiting September with EVs accounting for more than 25 per cent of sales. The company expects to sell 750,000 vehicles in the year. Chandra said Tata Motors is targeting 1.2 million annual sales by FY31 through new product categories, faster product interventions and expanded powertrain offerings.

Cars24 expects to be eligible to file DRHP by April: CFO

NEW DELHI: Cars24 expects to become eligible to file its draft red herring prospectus (DRHP) by April after completing its reverse flip from Singapore to India, CFO Shivanshu Makkar said.

The process is expected to take six to nine months, followed by Sebi approvals, pricing and book-building. The company's last funding round was in 2022 at a \$3.3 billion post-money valuation. Makkar said it has not raised fresh capital since then as it does not require funds. The proposed IPO would primarily create a war chest for expansion across India and overseas markets.

M&M weighs SUV price hike amid rising commodity costs

NEW DELHI: Mahindra & Mahindra (M&M) is considering another price increase across its SUV portfolio amid rising commodity costs, with a decision expected in the next couple of weeks, CEO Automotive Division Nalinikanth Gollagunta said.

The company has already raised prices three times this year—in January, April and July, with the July increase at about 2.7 per cent on SUVs.

Gollagunta said demand remains robust as vehicles are still priced below pre-GST levels. Mahindra currently has 60,000 units of monthly ICE capacity and 8,000 units of EV capacity.

CCPA fines Xboom ₹10 lakh for selling devices without nod

NEW DELHI: The CCPA has fined Bengaluru-based e-commerce firm Xboom Rs 10 lakh for listing anti-drone systems, drone jammers and GPS jammers without regulatory clearances. It directed Xboom to stop listing, advertising or selling the products without approvals, submit a compliance report within 15 days.

Its suo motu probe found six products listed under an "AntiDrone" category with jamming claims but no licensing disclosures. The authority said the conduct prima facie violated the Consumer Protection Act, 2019, E-Commerce Rules, 2020, Indian Telegraph Act, 1885 and Telecom Act, 2023.

BETS ON BRANDED MILK, VALUE-ADDED PRODUCTS ITC expands dairy biz in East India

OUR CORRESPONDENT Bengaluru, September 27

ITC is strengthening its presence in the fresh dairy segment in Eastern India through its flagship Aashirvaad brand, betting on rising demand for branded milk and value-added dairy products across Bihar, West Bengal and Jharkhand.

The diversified conglomerate, which entered the fresh dairy business in 2018 with the launch of Aashirvaad milk in Bihar and later expanded to West Bengal and Jharkhand, has emerged as the second-largest dairy player in Bihar with a lineup ranging from fresh milk to curd, paneer, lassi and Mishti Doi.



THE DIVERSIFIED CONGLOMERATE ENTERED THE FRESH DAIRY BUSINESS IN 2018 WITH THE LAUNCH OF AASHIRVAAD MILK IN BIHAR AND LATER EXPANDED TO WEST BENGAL AND JHARKHAND

KEY POINTS

- » ITC has emerged as the second-largest dairy player in Bihar with a lineup ranging from fresh milk to curd, paneer, lassi and Mishti Doi
- » As part of its expansion strategy, ITC has tailored its dairy portfolio to regional tastes, local consumption patterns and evolving consumer preference for quality-assured dairy products
- » Hemant Malik, CEO, Foods Division & Executive Director, ITC, said Eastern India will remain a key focus market for the company's dairy expansion plans, which offers significant headroom for expansion

"East is one of the most promising growth markets for the dairy category and will be central to our growth strategy in the coming years," Malik said.

For instance, in Bihar, over 80 per cent of consumers purchase loose milk, which presents a "compelling opportunity" to transition households to branded value-added dairy solutions that ensure quality, safety, and consistency, he said.

"In South India, consumers moved to branded curd over a decade ago, and we wanted to enable a similar transition in Bihar.

With our pouch curd offerings, we are helping consumers shift to branded curd that delivers assured quality and consistency, backed by the trust of ITC," said Malik.

Moreover, in the value-added segment, ITC is evaluating innovative and healthier dessert options as it seeks to broaden its portfolio beyond products such as Mishti Doi.

For ITC, the dairy business is "one of the fastest-growing categories witnessing high double-digit growth".

It currently operates dairy manufacturing

facilities at Munger, Patna, Muzaffarpur and Gaya in Bihar, Ranchi in Jharkhand, and Howrah and Bardhaman in West Bengal.

As part of Project Gomukh, ITC works with over 40,000 dairy farmers and directly procures milk from dairy farmers.

"The overarching objective of the project is to increase milk productivity and improve the quality of milk, while empowering rural farmers and increasing their income," it said.

ITC, which aspires to become India's leading FMCG player, has

expanded brand Aashirvaad beyond wheat flour into staples, spices and fresh foods, and even the frozen category, aiming to double consumer spends to over Rs 20,000 crore in the next five years.

According to the company's latest annual report, its 'Aashirvaad Svasti' fresh dairy portfolio maintained strong growth during FY26, aided by the strengthening of its premium milk variant 'Select' and robust growth in value-added products such as curd, paneer, Mishti Doi and lassi.

The portfolio is currently available across Bihar, West Bengal and Jharkhand, with the company continuing to expand its distribution network to deepen market penetration.

ITC has also strengthened its farmer-driven milk procurement network across the three eastern states to support the growing requirements of the dairy business.

The company said it supported around 33,300 dairy farmers across more than 560 villages of Bihar, West Bengal and Jharkhand through veterinary services, cattle feed distribution, deworming, mastitis control and other animal husbandry initiatives during the year.

OUR CORRESPONDENT New Delhi, September 27

Petronet LNG Ltd, India's biggest gas importer, has sought shareholders' approval to continue payment of commission to its directors, capped at 1 per cent of annual profits, for another five years from financial year 2026-27 to 2030-31.

The proposal, contained in the notice for the company's forthcoming general meeting, seeks approval for distribution of a sum not exceeding 1 per cent per annum of profits calculated under Section 198 of the Companies Act, 2013, among the directors in such amounts and proportions as may be decided by the board from time to time.

Shareholders had last approved the commission arrangement at the annual general meeting held on September 28, 2021, for FY22 to FY26. The earlier approvals for similar payments were granted in 2007, 2011 and 2016, according to the shareholder notice.

The company said the proposed continuation was being sought in view of its "healthy financial position".

For the fiscal year ended March 31, 2026, Petronet paid its CEO Akshay Kumar Singh and other directors a commission of Rs 26.5

lakh each, according to the annual report. They had received a commission of Rs 25.5 lakh in the previous fiscal year.

The commission took Singh's total remuneration in 2025-26 to Rs 3.64 crore, up from Rs 3.03 crore in the previous financial year.

Independent directors on the company board also got Rs 10 lakh each as commission on profit, besides the sitting fees. They were paid Rs 9.75 lakh commission in previous 2024-25 fiscal.

The actual commission paid to whole-time directors, including the managing director and CEO, and independent directors has remained well below the statutory ceiling, according to the company.

In FY26, whole-time directors, including the MD and CEO, were eligible for a maximum commission of Rs 79.5 lakh, while independent directors were eligible for Rs 55 lakh, taking the combined maximum to Rs 134.5 lakh, it said.

The company said the commission, as a percentage of profit before tax, was "marginal" and within the overall limits prescribed under the Companies Act, 2013.

Petronet had reported a net profit of Rs 3,843 crore on a revenue of Rs 43,495 crore in 2025-26. This compared with Rs 3,926 crore

profit on a revenue of Rs 50,980 crore in the previous 2024-25 fiscal year.

Section 197 of the Companies Act governs managerial remuneration, while its provisions cap remuneration payable to non-executive directors, including independent directors, at 1 per cent of net profits where the company has a managing or whole-time director or manager.

Singh last year got a 15-month extension till May 2027 as the managing director and chief executive officer of the country's biggest liquefied natural gas importer.

Singh, 65, who took over as Petronet CEO on February 1, 2020, for an initial five-year term, will now superannuate on May 12, 2027.

While the superannuation age in public sector companies is 60 years, Petronet, though headed by the government's top bureaucrat in the Union Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas, is registered as a private limited company.

Petronet is not under any government watchdog like CAG or CVC and is beyond the purview of RTI. Its board executives enjoy higher remuneration than PSUs and also retire at the age of 65 years.

A process to find a replacement for Singh has already started.

NSE empanels Augmont as key partner to promote EGRs

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA New Delhi, September 27

The National Stock Exchange (NSE) has empanelled Augmont Gold Tech, a subsidiary of Augmont Enterprises as a key partner for promoting electronic gold receipts, aimed at deepening India's organised gold market.

The strategic partnership is designed to simplify the creation and extinguishment of electronic gold receipts (EGR) and promote their trading on the exchange, NSE said in a statement on Saturday.

Under the arrangement, Augmont will provide technical and on-ground support for the development of the EGR product, drawing on its experience across the gold value chain.

The partnership will facilitate conversion of physical gold into EGRs and their subsequent conversion back into physical gold within the regulated ecosystem.

EGRs are dematerialised securities representing ownership of physical gold stored in Sebi-accredited vaults and held electronically through depositories.

Each receipt is fully backed by physical gold and can be traded on the exchange.

Large-scale electronics PLI scheme gets incentives worth ₹19,091 crore Sector attracted investments of ₹20,580.20 cr

AGENCIES New Delhi, September 27

Large-scale electronics manufacturing PLI beneficiaries have received the highest incentives of Rs 19,090.98 crore under the scheme till June this year, while the sector attracted investments of Rs 20,580.20 crore.

The government launched PLI schemes in 2020 for 14 sectors, with an approved outlay of Rs 1.91 lakh crore, to boost manufacturing, attract investment, promote exports,

generate jobs and reduce import dependence.

The PLI scheme for large-scale electronics manufacturing (LSEM) was launched in 2020 to boost domestic mobile phone manufacturing. As many as 32 beneficiary companies were approved under the scheme.

The scheme's tenure was extended by one year to 2025-26 from the original five-year period. Smartphone exports rose to about \$30 billion in 2025-26 from \$5.5 billion in 2021-22.

Overall, the government

disbursed Rs 36,754 crore to PLI beneficiaries from the scheme's launch in 2020 till June 30 this year, according to DPIIT data.

The pharma sector received Rs 6,662 crore, while Rs 3,271.440 crore and Rs 3,174.15 crore were disbursed to beneficiaries in food products and auto and auto components, respectively, as of June this year.

The government provides fiscal incentives to eligible PLI beneficiaries based on incremental sales over the base year.

AGENCIES New Delhi, September 27

Brazilian aerospace firm Embraer has partnered with Mahindra Group for the Indian Air Force's 60-aircraft Multi-Role Transport Aircraft (MTA) programme, offering its KC-390 Millennium, Embraer Defence & Security President and CEO Bosco Da Costa Junior said.

He said Embraer had chosen Mahindra as its military partner after conducting a market assessment following a C-390 demonstration in India in

EMBRAER IS POSITIONING KC-390 AS A REPLACEMENT FOR THE AN-32

2023. For its civilian aircraft business, Embraer is partnering with Adani Group to address demand for regional connectivity and flights.

"We are fully engaged to answer this, to comply with the timeline that they are looking for," Bosco said, adding that the KC-390

was a suitable fit for the requirement.

The MTA programme seeks 60 aircraft to replace the IAF's ageing transport fleet, with an option to add another 50 per cent. Five companies, including Mahindra, Tata, Hindustan Aeronautics Limited, Reliance Defence and Adani, have received the Request for Proposal.

Embraer is positioning the KC-390 as a replacement for the AN-32 and as a platform to standardise the IAF's medium transport fleet. Comparing it with

the C-130J, Bosco said the KC-390 can carry more and fly faster and higher.

He said the global KC-390 fleet was achieving 93% availability and 99% mission accomplishment. The aircraft has also demonstrated operations from unpaved desert runways during trials with the UAE Air Force.

With around 70 KC-390 aircraft on global order, Embraer is looking to expand its supply chain and MRO base in India, which Bosco described as "very strategic" for the company.

Dhamra Port becomes India's first large-scale pvt multi-cargo port to run fully on renewable power

It now meets over 90 lakh units of monthly power demand from renewable sources

AGENCIES New Delhi, September 27

Dhamra Port in Odisha, operated by Adani Ports and Special Economic Zone (APSEZ), has shifted its entire electricity consumption to renewable power, becoming India's first large-scale private multi-cargo port to operate fully on renewable electricity, the company said.

The port handles more than 48 million tonnes



(MT) of cargo annually and meets over 90 lakh units of monthly electricity demand from renewable sources. At its current operating level, the port's annualised renewable power

CLOSER LOOK

- » At its current operating level, the port's annualised renewable power consumption exceeds 108 gigawatt-hours (GWh)
- » The shift is part of APSEZ's long-term Net-Zero strategy and is expected to cut emissions associated with purchased electricity

consumption exceeds 108 gigawatt-hours (GWh).

The shift, effective August 2026, is part of APSEZ's long-term Net-Zero strategy and is expected to reduce emis-

sions associated with purchased electricity.

About 25-30 per cent of Dhamra's renewable electricity comes from APSEZ's captive hybrid power plant at Khavda in Gujarat, while

another 10-15 per cent is sourced through third-party access. The remaining requirement is met through a Green Consumer arrangement with Odisha's distribution utility.

Dhamra has an installed capacity of 60 MT and handled 48.8 MT of cargo in the financial year ended March 2026. Renewable electricity now powers its round-the-clock cargo handling, storage and rail-linked operations.

CORPORATE KALEIDOSCOPE



Rail Coach Factory, Kapurthala, celebrated its 40th Production Day at Waris Shah Hall, RCF. The occasion commemorated the commencement of production of the first GS coach at RCF on September 19, 1987, in presence of Sunil Kumar, Additional Member (Production Units), Railway Board (Chief Guest), Ajay Nandan, General Manager, RCF & Navita Nandan, President, RCF Women Welfare Organisation (Guests of Honour) and Deepak Tripathi, Director Technical, RITES (Special Invitee).

TRUMP HAS SHUNNED THE NEED FOR NEW AI REGULATIONS

OpenAI & Anthropic flag AI safety and seek to shape how it’s controlled

ASSOCIATED PRESS
San Francisco, September 27

As tech titans warned an AI-weary world that their own advanced systems could endanger humanity, the question emerged: What do they have to gain?

The answer may lie in the companies’ efforts to score political goals ahead of the US midterm elections and the money top artificial intelligence labs and their investors stand to make in much-anticipated listings on a jittery stock market.

The CEOs of Anthropic and OpenAI recently declared America’s cutting-edge models are so powerful, they’re dangerous, and need to be regulated and independently tested before being released. In a rare instance of unity, they have sketched alarming scenarios in essays, social media posts and speeches to the United Nations.

Along the way, they are shaping the conversation around how their technology should be controlled. With their rhetoric, the companies appear to be



seeking public favour and to set the terms for their own safety protocols in the unregulated market, experts, analysts and former government evaluators told The Associated Press.

Those aims may not exactly align with what Anthropic engineer Jacob Coxon sought when he quit via a post on X this month, calling for a pause on tech development to keep “superhuman” systems from eluding their makers’ control. But the companies saw his post as an opportunity to highlight their own safety efforts and position themselves as cau-

tious market leaders, just when they need fresh capital before going public on Wall Street.

President Donald Trump has shunned the need for new AI regulations, dismissing talk of risks to humanity as a “HOAX” designed to help China.

An Anthropic spokesperson said in response to questions for this story that the company has been calling for regulation for several years. An OpenAI spokesperson, Liz Bourgeois, noted the company recently paused training of its most advanced models.

“People want to know AI

KEY POINTS

» Anthropic & OpenAI CEOs declared America’s cutting-edge models are so powerful, they’re dangerous and need to be regulated and independently tested before being released

» An OpenAI spokesperson, Liz Bourgeois, noted the company recently paused training of its most advanced models

is being developed safely, and that starts with what companies like ours do ourselves,” Bourgeois said.

Calls for slowdown shift the conversation on AI risks

Turning the conversation toward unproven threats – and away from polarising issues such as data centres’ environmental impacts, uncontrolled hacking incidents, mass AI-powered surveillance and the AI systems’ use in warfare – puts Silicon Valley in a more comfortable position, said Sarah Shoker, who previously led OpenAI’s geopolitics team.

“Once again we’re talking about existential risk, while deprioritising a number of other safety-critical risks that exist today. If you look at the use of AI in military tech, you can see that these systems are already used to kill people,” said Shoker, a senior non-resident fellow at the University of California, Berkeley Risk & Security Lab.

As AI companies have gone from building chatbots to advanced AI “world models” with 3D awareness, debate has raged over how their technologies should be tested.

Problematic incidents have shown leading AI companies failing to police themselves or design safe experiments. In recent months, leading labs’ AI agents have hacked into external websites after being allowed to escape company training sandboxes, interacted with US government websites in unapproved ways, and appeared to achieve a mathematical breakthrough only to face accusations of stealing mathematicians’ work.

UP targets ₹5 lakh crore in annual exports by 2030, says Piyush Goyal

ANI NEWS
New Delhi, September 27

Uttar Pradesh targets an increase in annual exports from around Rs 2 lakh crore to Rs 5 lakh crore by 2030, Union Minister of Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal said while addressing the UP International Trade Show in Greater Noida, Uttar Pradesh.

Goyal stated that expanding exports, investments, and global market access will contribute to the state’s objective of becoming a \$1 trillion economy.

He highlighted that as global markets open up to India through FTAs, Uttar Pradesh’s entrepreneurs will have greater opportunities to access international markets. He said that the state has emerged as a preferred investment destination, supported by favourable industrial policies and proactive industrial schemes, with major corporations arriving across sectors to create new employment opportunities.

Goyal said the next frontier for Uttar Pradesh’s development lies in expanding exports in global markets, attracting international investments, strengthening tourism and building global recognition



Commerce and Industry Piyush Goyal

GOYAL STATED THAT EXPANDING EXPORTS, INVESTMENTS & GLOBAL MARKET ACCESS WILL CONTRIBUTE TO THE STATE’S OBJECTIVE OF BECOMING A \$1 TRILLION ECONOMY

for brands from the state.

He noted that the state is strengthening its foundation for greater global trade and progressing towards its economic targets. He also cited the development of expressways, modern airports, and industrial parks, alongside expanding capacity in sectors such as defence, semiconductors, electronics, and other high-technology domains. He pointed to the expansion of a large robotics manufacturing facility in Greater Noida as an exam-

ple of ongoing technological development.

“International events of this scale provide opportunities for direct access to global markets, enabling Uttar Pradesh’s diverse products, cuisines and services to reach international markets,” Goyal said.

The Minister pointed out that the event drew significant international participation, including six partner countries, hundreds of delegates and exhibitors, and multiple buyer-seller meetings. He emphasised that the combination of modern technology, international enterprises, and the evolving craftsmanship and technical skills of the state’s youth continues to drive development.

Goyal said the expanding global market access via FTAs, investments, tourism & international recognition of Uttar Pradesh’s products and brands would create new opportunities for the state’s entrepreneurs.

He called for active participation and cooperation from the trade & industrial community, stressing the need for coordination between the central and state governments, citizens, and youth to sustain the state’s export and economic growth trajectory.

Fortis confident forensic audit will clear it in Singh Brothers case

AGENCIES
New Delhi, September 27

Fortis Healthcare Ltd said it is confident an independent forensic audit will establish that the hospital chain had no role in the transfer of shares by its erstwhile promoters, Malvinder & Shivinder Mohan Singh.

The Supreme Court, in an order dated September 25, disposed of Fortis’ special leave petition challenging the Delhi HC’s August 31 order in the matter involving Daiichi Sankyo Company Ltd & Singh Brothers.

The top court allowed the forensic audit to proceed but clarified that

observations in the High Court judgment challenged by Fortis were “tentative and only for the purpose of making out a case for forensic audit”. It also said the audit must be conducted independently and without being influenced by those observations.

Fortis said it was a “complete stranger” to the dispute between Daiichi Sankyo and the Singh Brothers and was never a party to their arbitration proceedings. It also said it was neither a judgment debtor nor a garnishee in respect of Daiichi Sankyo’s decree. The company said it had no power to control the transfer of shares owned by its erstwhile pro-

motors and received no proceeds from the dissipation of their shareholding. It also reiterated that the Delhi HC had imposed no liability, penalty or fine on Fortis. By March 2018, the Singh Brothers’ shareholding had fallen below 1 per cent & they had resigned from the board.

In June 2018, the new board initiated a competitive bidding process, resulting in Northern TK Venture Pte Ltd, part of Malaysia-based IHH Healthcare Berhad, becoming Fortis’ promoter shareholder. The investment was made in November 2018 through a fresh issue of equity shares after statutory & regulatory approvals.

Geopolitical developments, crude oil to steer market in holiday-shortened week: Analysts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 27

Investors will focus on geopolitical developments, crude oil prices, bond yields and macroeconomic data announcements to determine market trends during the holiday-shortened week, analysts said.

According to experts, the US-Iran diplomatic talks and crude oil prices will drive global market sentiment. Moreover, the market is likely to remain cautious as crude oil prices, geopolitical developments and global bond yields continue to influence near-term direction, they said.

Equity markets would



remain closed on Friday for Mahatma Gandhi Jayanti.

“Globally, developments around US-Iran diplomacy and crude oil prices will remain critical. Any progress on a framework for reopening the Strait of Hormuz could ease energy prices and provide some relief to India’s import bill and the rupee, while renewed geopolitical tensions could keep volatility elevated,” Ajit Mishra,

SVP - Research, Religare Broking, said.

On the domestic front, industrial production data for August and the HSBC manufacturing PMI reading will be released during the week, he added. Additionally, market participants will closely monitor FII activity and the upcoming monthly auto sales figures.

“Global bond yields will also remain important following the Federal Reserve’s September policy decision. Further increases in yields and the dollar could weigh on emerging-market capital flows, while a moderation in yields could provide some relief. “The rupee will remain

another important factor to watch, with persistent oil-related demand for dollars and continued FII outflows potentially keeping the currency under pressure, although RBI intervention has helped contain excessive volatility,” Ponmudi R, CEO - Enrich Money, an online trading and wealth tech firm, said.

In addition, a series of economic data releases from the US will also be important for global risk sentiment, he added.

Last week, the BSE benchmark Sensex declined 399.22 points, or 0.53 per cent, and the NSE Nifty dipped 205.9 points, or 0.88 per cent.

Bullion prices likely to face another choppy spell in holiday-shortened week: Analysts

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 27

Bullion prices are expected to face another choppy spell, with US data, West Asia tensions and their impact on crude prices set to test bullion sentiment during a holiday-shortened week, analysts said.

Market participants will shift their focus to the US data calendar, with consumer confidence, GDP and PCE inflation readings, alongside Eurozone inflation. Additionally, manufacturing PMIs, speeches from Federal Reserve officials and the US non-farm payrolls report will provide further cues for bullion sentiment, they added.

Commodity markets would remain closed on Friday for Mahatma Gandhi Jayanti.

On the MCX, gold futures for October delivery fell Rs 3,500, or nearly 2.3 per cent, last week to Rs 1.5 lakh per 10 grams. Silver futures declined Rs 6,907, or 3 per cent, to Rs 2.34 per kilogram.

In global markets, Comex gold futures for December delivery dropped \$103.7, or 2.34 per cent, last week to \$4,321.2 per ounce. Silver fell \$2.35, or 3.5 per cent, to \$64.80 an ounce in New York.

NMDC commissions 2-MTPA pellet plant at Nagarnar under ₹5,427 cr integrated project

MPOST BUREAU
Hyderabad, September 27

NMDC Ltd has commissioned its 2 million tonne per annum (MTPA) pellet plant at Nagarnar in Chhattisgarh as part of a Rs 5,427 crore integrated project of iron ore processing, pipeline and pellet making, connecting its iron ore operations at Bacheli with its steel plant at Nagarnar.

The project comprises a new iron ore processing plant at Bacheli, a 15 MTPA slurry pipeline and the 2

MTPA pellet plant at Nagarnar. The 135 km slurry pipeline carries processed iron ore concentrate from Bacheli to Nagarnar, providing an alternative to transporting the material by road.

Maiden production from the pellet plant was monitored live from NMDC’s headquarters by Chairman and MD Amitava Mukherjee and senior leadership, as adverse weather prevented them from travelling to the project site.

The facilities will enable NMDC to process iron ore

finer and slimes from its Bailadila mines into concentrate and subsequently convert the concentrate into pellets using Straight Grate Induration technology.

“Today is a day of immense pride for everyone at NMDC. This has not been an easy project to execute. It involved the processing facilities, the actual slurry pipeline and the pellet plant. But today is a red-letter day—a day we have been waiting for a long time. This is the day when our collective dream

is coming true,” Mukherjee said. The commissioning strengthens NMDC’s presence across the iron ore value chain and adds a value-added product to its portfolio. The pipeline passes through 61 villages in Bastar and Dantewada districts, reducing road movement of processed ore and dependency on Railways.

The project is part of NMDC’s broader expansion & diversification strategy to increase its iron ore output capacity to 100 million tonnes in the long term.

Indian durables mkt to reach ₹3-3.25L cr by 2030, create ₹50K cr local mfg: Report

‘India is expected to remain one of the world’s fastest-growing consumer durables markets over the next five years’

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA
New Delhi, September 27

India’s consumer durables market is expected to witness significant growth to touch Rs 3-3.25 lakh crore by 2030, creating an additional Rs 40,000-50,000 crore opportunity for domestic value addition across materials and component manufacturing, a joint report by Boston Consulting Group (BCG) and industry body CII said.

The report said India is expected to remain one of the world’s fastest-growing

consumer durables markets over the next five years, driven by rising household penetration, growing nuclearisation of families, higher incomes, easier financing, wider distribution and increasing premiumisation.

In comparison, China, the world’s largest market, is expected to grow at 1-2 per cent annually through 2030, while the US is projected to expand by 3 per cent and Japan by 1-3 per cent, according to the report. “India is set to remain the fastest-growing major consumer dura-

bles market, growing 8-10 per cent annually till 2030 and reach \$30-35 billion by 2030, with Room Airconditioner growth leading the market,” the report said.

However, the report cautioned that a significant portion of this opportunity could continue to be met through imports unless domestic component and material capacities are scaled up.

According to the report, localisation of bill of materials (BOM) currently ranges between 25 per cent and 70 per cent across categories,

CLOSER LOOK

» In comparison, China, the world’s largest market, is expected to grow at 1-2% annually through 2030, while the US is projected to expand by 3% and Japan by 1-3%, according to the report

» ‘India is set to remain the fastest-growing major consumer durables market, growing 8-10% annually till 2030 and reach \$30-35 billion by 2030 and reach \$30-35 billion by 2030,’ the report said

with televisions and air conditioners at the lower end and refrigerators and washing machines at the higher end. This is estimated to rise to 30-80 per cent by 2030 as domestic component and material capacities

are built up.

The report identified TV display panels, RAC compressors, refrigerator insulation and washing machine motors as key components where the localisation gap persists. “As domestic com-

ponent and material capacity ramps up, localisation is estimated to rise to 30-80 per cent by 2030,” it said, adding “Technology partnerships and joint ventures will be required in areas where know-how is concentrated among a few global suppliers, while cluster-led manufacturing can help address scale and cost disadvantages.”

Moreover, the report highlighted that global consumer durables export is expected to touch USD 900-950 billion by 2030, but India’s share of global trade

remains below 1 per cent. Although durable’s exports are growing, they remain concentrated in neighbouring markets and regions such as SAARC countries and the UAE, with limited presence in major global import markets, it added.

“India faces a material cost disadvantage vs leading exporters, driven by scale, backward integration, technology & policy support gaps, and compounded by limited testing, certification & compliance infrastructure,” it said. It cited Thailand as an exam-

ple of a coordinated export ecosystem, noting that the country’s share of global air conditioner exports rose from 16 per cent to 22 per cent between 2010 and 2025, making it the world’s second-largest AC exporter.

The report called for India to build a similar export ecosystem, including manufacturing clusters linked to component ecosystems, support for joint ventures and technology acquisition, shared testing and certification infrastructure, and lower financing costs.



‘Ramayana will introduce audiences to Indian culture’

Ranbir Kapoor said that ‘Lord Ram is someone who never tried to be a hero’

MUMBAI: In a cross-cultural moment, popular American YouTuber Jimmy Donaldson, better known as MrBeast, surprised the audience on Saturday by chanting ‘Jai Shri Ram’ at a promotional event for the upcoming film ‘Ramayana’.

‘Ramayana’, an ambitious adaptation of the Indian epic, features Ranbir Kapoor as Lord Ram, South Indian actors Sai Pallavi as Goddess Sita and Yash as Ravana. The film is helmed by Nitesh Tiwari of ‘Dangal’ fame.

When an audience member shouted, ‘Jai Shri Ram, MrBeast’, Kapoor helped the digital creator repeat the chant. To everyone’s delight, MrBeast said, ‘Jai Shri Ram’.

“It’s been a lot of fun and it’s amazing to see part of the film (referring to the trailer of the film); it looks phenomenal,” MrBeast said.

The YouTu-



ber was initially scheduled to interact with the ‘Ramayana’ team, including Kapoor, Pallavi and Tiwari, among others, but the interaction did not take place. The event, which was scheduled to begin at 1:30 pm, eventually commenced at around 5 pm.

Producer Namit Malhotra apologised for

the delay, saying there were ‘logistics beyond our control’.

Talking about the significance of ‘Ramayana’, Kapoor said the epic and its central character of Lord Ram are ‘deeply etched in the subconscious of every Indian’. “Lord Ram is someone who never tried to be a hero; he is known as Maryada Purushottam, which symbolises that he is an ideal man. He is born as a Prince; he could’ve had everything, but he sacrificed everything to fulfil his father’s promise and for his duties,” the Bollywood star said.

“There’s a word called ‘dharma’ in our culture, which means duty, commitment to your duties. He is a perfect man,” he said to MrBeast.

AGENCIES

Melissa is open to reprise ‘Scream’ role

Barrera would join the film only if Spyglass Media Group sells the rights

LOS ANGELES: Melissa Barrera said she would join another ‘Scream’ film to reprise her role, as she admires the franchise, but only if current rights holder Spyglass Media Group sells the rights.

The actress earlier had a fallout with production banner Spyglass Media Group. Barrera was fired from ‘Scream 7’ in November 2023 over social media posts regarding the Israel-Hamas conflict. The studio claimed the actress crossed into antisemitism and hate speech.

The actress has earlier starred in ‘Scream’ and ‘Scream VI’, where she essayed the role of Sam Carpenter.

“Not with the company which currently holds the rights,” she said on ‘Just Watch’ when asked about her return. The actress said the company never apologised to her.

“I love the franchise. I had an amazing time making those movies. But a lot of the hate and the difficulty that I’ve faced in the last years is because the leadership of that company made it a point to label me something that I’m not and they never apologised, even when I was proven right,” she added.

PTI



IIC presents ‘Journey of Colours’

A solo exhibition by Sadaf Beg Khan, it is on view at IIC’s Art Gallery



MPOST
New Delhi, September 27

A solo exhibition by Sadaf Beg Khan, ‘Journey of Colours’ presents artworks inspired by emotions, experiences and everyday life. The artist has explored varied moods, ideas and perspectives, inviting viewers to engage with the distinctive expressions and narratives that shape her artistic practice. Sadaf Beg Khan is a visual artist whose practice draws deeply from nature and explores themes of femininity, beauty and vulnerability. With a distinctive

SADAF BEG KHAN IS A VISUAL ARTIST WHOSE PRACTICE DRAWS DEEPLY FROM NATURE

blend of creativity and visual storytelling, the collection offers an engaging experience for art enthusiasts. It provides a space to connect with the artworks and appreciate their unique expressions.

The exhibition will remain open daily from 11 am to 7 pm at the India International Centre’s Art Gallery.



Vicky Kaushal releases first-look poster of ‘Love & War’

NEW DELHI: Vicky Kaushal released the first look poster of his film ‘Love & War’, directed by Sanjay Leela Bhansali.

The actor shared the post on his ‘Instagram’ handle on Saturday, which featured him with a cigarette. “Nazre milengi, lekin hatengi nahin! Sanjay Leela Bhansali’s ‘Love & War’ on 21st January 2027. See you at the movies,” read the caption of the post.

The film is set to be released on January 21,



2027 and also features Alia Bhatt and Ranbir Kapoor alongside the actor. The makers have also released posters of Bhatt and Kapoor.

‘Love & War’ also

THE POSTER FEATURES THE ACTOR WITH A CIGARETTE

serves as the first collaboration for Kaushal and Bhansali.

The film reunites Bhatt and Kapoor with the filmmaker. Bhatt was the protagonist of Bhansali’s last big-screen outing, ‘Gangubai Kathiawadi’ in 2022. Kapoor made his acting debut with ‘Saawariya’.



MTV VMAS 2026 NOMINATIONS

Madonna leads; Taylor Swift to make history

SWIFT WILL RECEIVE THE INAUGURAL ARTIST DIRECTOR HONOURS, BECOMING THE MOST AWARDED ARTIST IN VMA HISTORY



The MTV Awards are here. Earlier this week, it was announced that Taylor Swift will receive the inaugural Artist Director Honours, becoming the most awarded artist in VMA history.

Swift is currently tied with Beyoncé for the title of most-awarded musician in VMA history. They have 30 each. (Eminem is the male artist with the most VMAs, with 15.) The new award, which, according to the VMAs, is meant to recognise artists ‘whose work behind the camera has expanded the possibilities of music video and advanced the art of visual storytelling’, will bring her total to 31.

She will also debut the music video for her new song, ‘Patient Zero’, during the award show. Swift directed the visual, which stars Colin Farrell and Dakota Johnson. ‘Patient Zero’ is also her first single since marrying Kansas City Chiefs tight

end Travis Kelce at Madison Square Garden in July.

The two-hour MTV Video Music Awards show will be broadcast live on CBS on September 27, at 7:30 p.m. Eastern and 4:30 p.m. Pacific, from the Peacock Theatre in Los Angeles. It’s the first time since 2017 the VMAs have picked a location that isn’t in New York or New Jersey.

The VMAs are also simulcast on MTV and will be available to stream on ‘Paramount+’ in the U.S. It’ll become available to stream the next day on ‘Paramount+’ and MTV.

Snoop Dogg, a 13-time VMAs nominee and three-time winner, will host. Snoop made his debut on the VMAs stage in 1994. He closed the show in 1999 with Dr Dre and Eminem and returned for a tribute to the Notorious B.I.G. and again for a performance with Eminem in 2022.

Madonna leads the 2026 MTV Video Music Award nominations. The pop superstar has been nominated

SWIFT IS CURRENTLY TIED WITH BEYONCÉ FOR THE TITLE OF MOST-AWARDED MUSICIAN IN VMA HISTORY

every decade of her musical career. She has 19 competitive MTV VMA wins and in 1986 became the first solo female artist to receive the Video Vanguard Award. She’s up for 11 awards at this year’s ceremony, including video, artist and song of the year, as well as best collaboration, dance, direction, art direction, cinematography, editing, choreography and visual effects.

Taylor Swift follows with the second-most nominations, with nine.

AGENCIES